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24-System

A tactical survival-horror tabletop RPG framework centered on body commitment, positional control, and consequence-forward play.

This README compiles the current markdown rules and setting notes in `fiction/24system`.

Design Premise

The 24-System is built around these ideas:

- Competent characters under escalating pressure
- Choices about commitment and risk, not action-point optimization
- Injuries that degrade capability over time
- Fear that biases behavior without removing agency
- Fiction-first resolution with fast adjudication

Core Resolution (`core.md`)

- Roll skill dice plus Leverage dice (if any)
- Result is highest die
- Compare against DC (raised by Pressure)
- Outcome bands:
  - Legendary Success (24+)
  - Partial Critical (any die at max)
  - Success
  - Miss
- Optional push-your-luck reroll:
  - Accept Minor Complication and reroll
  - If reroll still fails, escalate to Critical Failure and Major Complication

Leverage/Pressure replacement for advantage/disadvantage:

- Leverage adds a bonus die by tier (`d4` to `d12`)
- Pressure increases DC instead of removing dice

Action Economy: RHLF / "Ralph" (`RLHF.md`)

Characters commit body anchors to perform actions:

- `L`: primary hand
- `R`: secondary hand
- `H`: head (attention, targeting, intent)
- `F`: feet (movement, balance, stance)

If an anchor is injured, related actions degrade. If disabled, those actions can become unavailable.

Combat Overview (`combat.md`, `defense.md`, `movement.md`, `weapons.md`, `wounds.md`)

Baseline Combat Concepts

- Guard is automatic when aware, unengaged, and not committing `H`
- Combat uses range states (Separated, Melee, Grappling), not grid distance
- Advancing into guarded space is contested
- Multiple guards stack by `+2 DC` per extra defender
- Dodge is preserved after normal movement, but Sprint/Leap normally consumes Dodge until next turn

Core Declared Actions

- Attack (`L`)
- Focused Attack (`L+H`)
- Full Martial Attack (`L(R)HF`)
- Advance (`F`)
- Move (`F`)
- Covering Fire (`L+H`, ammo, attention disruption)

Reactive Defenses

- Base defense (no active defense): attack DC 13
- Dodge: athletics-based avoidance, stamina cost
- Parry: melee-based interception/deflection, weapon risk
- Block: interception/absorption, strongest with shields

Cover and Concealment

- Concealment primarily affects perception/hit chance
- Cover at range increases DC
- Cover in melee is mostly active/interposed and depends on committed limbs/position
- Cover stacks with active defenses where applicable

Movement

- Movement Rate (MR) baseline 6 (human, unencumbered)
- Armor/packs apply only worst movement penalty source
- Sprint costs stamina for temporary MR increase
- Leg injuries reduce MR cumulatively

Weapons and Identity

Weapon identity is driven by partial-critical behavior and qualities:

- Primary properties: Precision, Chopping, Crushing

- Qualities: Reach, Parry, Brace, Improvised
- One-handed baseline: 1 wound
- Two-handed baseline: 2 wounds
- Ranged tools differentiated by limb commitment and reload friction

Wounds, Armor, and Trauma

- Region tracks: each arm, head, shared legs, core
- Wound progression: OK -> Injured -> Disabled -> Missing (region-specific behavior)
- Armor is a single worn unit that converts wounds to stamina loss (Light/Medium/Heavy)
- Core wound thresholds drive failing, dying, death states

Stress Model (`fear-and-madness.md`)

Fear track runs 0-6:

- Lower levels increase caution/hypervigilance
- Mid levels introduce hesitation entering hostile danger
- High levels reduce available anchor commitment
- Top level causes breakdown/withdrawal

Madness is emergent from accumulated survival scars (Banes), not a separate meter.

Status Effects (`status-effects.md`)

Common tactical conditions are defined in one place:

- Blind
- Prone
- Grabbed
- Pinned
- Restrained
- Disoriented
- Stunned
- Silenced
- Incapacitated
- Unconscious
- Bleeding

Character Growth

Character Creation (`charactercreation.md`)

- No attributes (no STR/DEX/INT)
- Assign 1 specialty, 1 strong, 2 competent skills

- Competent tier is `d10 + d12 + 2` (Rank 1)
- Unassigned skills use vanilla roll (`2d12`)
- Choose 2 traits
- Add gear and narrative details

Advancement (`advancement.md`)

- No XP or levels
- Advancement at story-arc boundaries
- Declare one training focus per arc (skill or trait)
- Gain one skill tier (pyramid-limited) or one earned trait per arc

Skill Framework (`skills.md`)

Action-centric skills define what can be attempted:

- Athletics
- Melee
- Ranged
- Thievery
- Lore
- Social
- Magic
- Science

Key framework updates:

- Contested checks: initiator rolls against defender average (rounded up)
- Unified legendary conversion rule
- Per-action duration tags (`Instant`, `Short`, `Extended`, `Scene`, `Sustained`)
- Stealth awareness ladder and scene-based stealth handling

Perception Philosophy (`perception.md`)

No passive perception stat. Discovery is narrative and interaction-driven:

- Players ask specific questions and describe methods
- Guide seeds fair clues for secrets/traps
- Hidden features should be foreshadowed through sensory/environmental evidence

Magic Model (`spells.md`)

Spellcasting axioms:

- Magic always works in type
- Rolls determine manifestation quality and consequence, not binary success/fizzle
- Failures escalate through backlash, danger, and cost

Current spell writeups:

- Elder Sign
- The Colour Out of Space
- The Call
- Pseudo-Apotheosis
- The Unveiling

Playtest Materials

- `playtest-packet.md`: player-facing quick rule packet and expectations
- `playtest-characters.md`: fast combat reference

Setting / Thematic Documents

- `Atrocitas.md`: Atrocitas Sine Auctore concept (atrocity without authorship)
- `monsters/echo-born-other.md`: Echo-Born Other entity and stat block
- `authors-note.md`: design intent and authorship note
- `quote.md`: thematic line

File Index

- `advancement.md`: arc-based training and progression
- `Atrocitas.md`: cognitive-horror theorem and ontology note
- `authors-note.md`: author statement and design philosophy
- `charactercreation.md`: chargen flow, skills, traits
- `combat.md`: warding, range states, core combat actions
- `core.md`: outcomes, push-your-luck, leverage/pressure
- `defense.md`: active defense options, cover/concealment
- `fear-and-madness.md`: fear track and emergent madness model
- `movement.md`: MR, encumbrance, terrain, sprinting
- `monsters/echo-born-other.md`: monster ecology, behavior, stat block
- `perception.md`: narrative discovery and secret-door guidance
- `playtest-characters.md`: quick combat cheat sheet
- `playtest-packet.md`: player onboarding packet
- `quote.md`: thematic quote
- `RLHF.md`: body-anchor action economy
- `skills.md`: skill action vocabularies
- `status-effects.md`: common tactical conditions and their mechanical effects
- `spells.md`: spell axioms and examples
- `weapons.md`: weapon properties, qualities, ranged action economy
- `wounds.md`: hit locations, trauma ladder, armor conversion

Notes for Next Pass

Likely cleanup targets identified while compiling:

- Standardize anchor naming (`RHLF` vs `RLHF`, and `F` vs "Legs (L)" in one defense section)
- Resolve encoding artifacts (smart quotes/dashes rendering as mojibake in terminal output)
- Align push-your-luck language between `core.md` and `playtest-packet.md`
- Fill unfinished sections (`Blocking cover` heading)
- Unify terminology for Guide/GM and action labels across reference docs

24-System: Success & Failure Levels

In the 24-System, you roll a pool of dice based on your skill and any situational benefits, then compare your result to a **Difficulty (DC)**.

Your **result** is the **highest single die** rolled, after applying bonuses and Leverage.

Outcome Levels

Legendary Success (24+) If your final result is **24 or higher**, you achieve an extraordinary, cinematic success.

- You bypass normal limitations
- You gain a powerful additional benefit
- The Guide may allow effects beyond the original intent of the action

Legendary results represent moments where preparation, skill, and circumstance align perfectly.

Partial Critical (Max Die) If **any die** in your roll shows its **maximum value** (e.g., 12 on a d12, 10 on a d10), you gain a **Partial Critical**, even if you do not reach 24.

Partial Criticals grant a flourish or immediate benefit, such as:

- Acting faster
- Avoiding a minor consequence
- Impressing observers
- Gaining positional advantage
- Reducing the impact of Pressure

Partial Criticals reward strong execution even under difficult conditions.

Success If your result **meets or exceeds the DC**, you succeed as intended.

You accomplish your goal cleanly, with no added cost.

Push Your Luck (Optional Reroll)

If you fail a roll, you may choose to **push your luck**.

When you do so:

- You must **accept a Minor Complication** immediately.
- You **reroll the entire dice pool**.
- You must keep the new result.

This represents forcing the action through stress, danger, or desperation.

Outcomes After Pushing

After the reroll, resolve the outcome normally, with the following escalation rules:

- **Reroll Succeeds (meets or exceeds DC)**
  You succeed, but the **Minor Complication applies**.
- **Reroll Succeeds with a Partial Critical**
  You gain the Partial Critical benefit, but the **Minor Complication still applies**.
- **Reroll Fails**
  The failure **escalates into a Critical Failure**.
  You must take a **Major Complication** instead of a minor one.

Pushing your luck always carries risk, success comes at a cost, failure compounds.

Critical Failure

A **Critical Failure** represents a loss of control caused by escalation, bad positioning, or pushing beyond safe limits.

A Critical Failure occurs when:

- A pushed reroll still fails,
- The Guide declares the situation has escalated beyond safe limits

On a Critical Failure:

- You fail the action

- You must accept a **Major Complication**
- The situation escalates immediately and meaningfully

Critical Failures are not about incompetence, they are about pressure, risk, and consequence.

Miss (No Push)

If your result is below the DC and you **choose not to push**:

- You fail to achieve your goal
- No complication is automatically applied
- The Guide advances the situation naturally

Examples include:

- Time passes
- The environment changes
- Opponents reposition or react
- New information or threats emerge

Failure should move the scene forward, not stall play.

Minor Complications

Minor Complications represent setbacks, costs, or unintended consequences.

Examples include:

- Dropping or fumbling an item
- Making noise or drawing attention
- Taking minor harm or fatigue
- Losing time or position
- Using up resources
- Leaving evidence behind
- Suffering temporary disorientation

Minor Complications should complicate the situation without stopping play.

Major Complications

Major Complications represent serious consequences or dramatic turns.

Examples include:

- Suffering a wound or lasting injury
- Breaking important gear
- Being discovered or trapped

- Endangering an ally
- Losing a critical resource
- Escalating the threat or alerting powerful enemies

Major Complications always change the situation in a meaningful way.

Leverage & Pressure

The 24-System replaces traditional advantage and disadvantage with **Leverage** and **Pressure**.

This system rewards preparation and smart play, while keeping penalties clear and fair.

Leverage

Leverage represents favorable circumstances such as:

- Positioning
- Planning
- Superior tools or gear
- Teamwork
- Surprise or momentum

Each point of Leverage grants a **bonus die**, using the step progression below.

You may gain multiple points of Leverage from different sources.

Leverage Dice Progression

When you have Leverage, add **one bonus die** to your roll:

Leverage	Bonus Die
1	d4
2	d6
3	d8
4	d10
5	d12

Roll all dice together.
Your result is the **highest single die**.

Leverage dice are never negative.
If circumstances are poor, Pressure applies instead.

Advantage Step Rule

When a rule says an action gains **advantage**, grant exactly **one Leverage step**:

- Start at `d4`.
- Each additional advantage source increases by one die step (`d4 -> d6 -> d8 -> d10 -> d12`).
- Cap the bonus die at the acting skill roll's **minimum base die size** (before Leverage).
- Advantage effects do not jump multiple steps unless multiple separate sources apply.

Pressure

Pressure represents difficulty, danger, or constraint, such as:

- Darkness, smoke, or noise
- Injury, exhaustion, or fear
- Environmental hazards
- Time pressure
- Opposition or resistance

Pressure **does not affect your dice**.

Instead, Pressure **increases the DC** of the action.

Applying Pressure

Each point of Pressure raises the DC by **+1 to +2**, depending on severity.

Typical examples:

- Low light: +1 DC
- Darkness or smoke: +2 DC
- Wounded or exhausted: +2 DC
- Severe injury or panic: +3 or more DC

The Guide should state the adjusted DC clearly before the roll.

Status Effects

Common status conditions (Blind, Prone, Grabbed, Pinned, Incapacitated, etc.) are defined in `status-effects.md`.

- Status effects may add DC, remove available actions, or constrain RLHF anchors.

- If both Pressure and a status effect apply, use both unless a specific rule says otherwise.
- If multiple statuses affect the same action, use the most restrictive limit and highest relevant DC increase.

Key Principles

- Players only roll extra dice when things are going well
- Difficulty comes from harder targets, not worse dice
- Leverage rewards smart play
- Pressure keeps danger real without killing momentum

This system preserves excitement while maintaining tension and fairness.

Optional Rule: Crushing Pressure

In extreme situations, the Guide may declare **Crushing Pressure**.

- You may not gain Leverage on this roll
- The DC is increased significantly

Use this sparingly, for moments of overwhelming danger.

The RHLF ("Ralph") Action System

The 24-System uses a **body-anchored action economy** called the **RHLF Action System**, informally known as the **"Ralph" system**.
Rather than abstract action points, characters commit **parts of their body** to perform actions.

RHLF stands for:

- **L** – Primary Hand (the hand holding the weapon)
- **R** – Secondary Hand (optional or supporting)
- **H** – Head (awareness, targeting, balance, intent)
- **F** – Feet (stance, movement, positioning)

These anchors determine **what actions are possible**, **what bonuses apply**, and **what happens when a character is injured or exhausted**.

Handedness and Notation

The labels **L** and **R** are **arbitrary** and do **not** represent biological handedness.

- **L** always denotes the *hand currently holding or leading the action*.
- **R** denotes the *supporting hand*, when applicable.

- Left- and right-handed characters function identically.
- The system assumes no inherent advantage to either side.

This convention exists solely to keep action notation compact and readable.

Action Commitment

Every action specifies which body anchors it requires.

Examples:

- `L` – One-handed action
- `LH` – One-handed action with focus or targeting
- `(R)LHF` – A fully committed martial action using:
  - Primary hand
  - Optional secondary hand (two-handed weapon)
  - Head (awareness, timing)
  - Feet (stance and balance)

Parentheses indicate optional commitment, usually for two-handed weapons or heavier techniques.

Why This Matters

The RHLF system directly connects:

- **Weapon choice**
- **Positioning**
- **Injury**
- **Fatigue**
- **Range control**

If a body anchor is **impaired**, actions that use it suffer penalties.
If a body anchor is **disabled**, actions that require it are unavailable.

This creates a natural degradation of capability over time without introducing complex tracking or special conditions.

Design Goals

The RHLF system is designed to:

- Make injuries immediately meaningful
- Reduce abstract action bookkeeping
- Encourage tactical adaptation instead of static optimal play
- Ensure that combat fiction and mechanics always align

Characters are not limited by arbitrary action counts, but by **what their bodies can still do**.

Detailed rules for injuries, impairment, fatigue, and specific action types are presented in later sections.

Basic Combat Actions (RHLF)

This section presents the **default combat actions** available to all characters. These actions are designed for fast play and do not require players to assemble body anchors manually.

Advanced options, custom assemblies, and special feats are presented in later sections.

Automatic Actions (Always Available)

The following actions do **not** require declaration unless otherwise noted.
They represent instinctive, trained, or reflexive behavior.

Default Guard (H)

- Requires: `H`
- Automatic while:
  - You are aware of danger
  - You are not currently engaged
  - You are not committing your Head (H) to another task

Effect

- You threaten space and contest enemy advances
- Guard is directional and limited to one approach by default
- Guard ends immediately if you commit `H` elsewhere (attack, cast a spell, aim, etc.)

Default Guard represents attention, posture, and readiness, not an attack.

Defense

Defense represents instinctive reactions to incoming threats.
You may use **one defensive option** per incoming attack, if eligible.

Reaction baseline:

- Defensive reactions do not require `H` unless a rule explicitly says so.
- A defense anchor (`L`, `R`, `F`) must have been left unspent on your own turn to be available as a reaction.
- Footwork exception: normal movement/reposition keeps Dodge available.
- If you used Sprint or Leap, Dodge is unavailable until your next turn unless a trait overrides it.

Dodge (F)

- Requires: `F`
- Effect:
  - Attempt to evade an attack through movement or positioning
  - May avoid damage entirely
  - Less effective if feet are impaired or terrain is poor
  - Still available after normal movement
  - Not available after Sprint/Leap unless a trait says otherwise

Dodge represents footwork, balance, and quick repositioning.

Parry (L)

- Requires: `L`
- Weapon required
- Effect:
  - Redirect or deflect an incoming melee attack
  - Weapon may lose integrity on Partial Criticals or worse

Only weapons with the **Parry** quality may parry while also attacking.

Block (R)

- Requires: `R`
- Shield or suitable object required
- Effect:
  - Absorb or deflect an attack
  - Shield or object may lose integrity

Block is reliable but consumes your secondary hand.

Core Combat Actions

These actions are declared on your turn.

Wild Swing

- Requires: `L`
- Optional: `(R)` for two-handed weapons
- Effect:
  - Make a standard attack with your weapon increasing the DC by 2.
  - Deal wounds according to weapon type
  - Apply weapon properties on Partial Criticals

Focused Attack

- Requires: `LH`
- Effect:
  - Make an attack with improved accuracy or control
  - Commonly used for called shots or careful strikes

Focused attacks trade flexibility for precision.

Full Martial Attack

- Requires: `L(R)HF`
- Effect:
  - Make a fully committed attack
  - Typically grants one advantage step (see `core.md` Advantage Step Rule) or bonus damage
  - Leaves you unable to maintain Guard against additional approaches

This represents total commitment of body and intent.

Targeting Hit Locations

Attacks may target specific body regions.

- **Default target:** Core
- **Called targets:** Left Arm, Right Arm, Legs, or Head

DC Modifiers

- Targeting **arms or legs:** no DC change
- Targeting **head:** `+2 DC`

On a Hit

- Apply wounds to the declared target location.

This applies to Wild Swing, Focused Attack, and Full Martial Attack unless a specific ability says otherwise.

Blind Targeting

- If the attacker cannot visually target, apply Blind rules from `status-effects.md`.
- Default combat baseline for blind strikes/grapples is `+4 DC` unless fiction supports a lower/higher category.

Advance

- Requires: `F`
- Effect:
  - Attempt to move one range state closer to a target
  - May be contested by Guard

Advance is used to close distance or force engagement.

Move

- Requires: `F`
- Effect:
  - Reposition, back away, or change facing
  - Backing away is safe unless surrounded or restrained

Movement does not break Guard unless it commits the Head (H).

Covering Fire

- Requires: `LH`
- Expends ammo
- Effect:
  - Does **not** deal damage
  - Forces an opponent using Guard to choose between:
    - Breaking Guard
    - Taking the attack
  - On Partial Critical, both occur

Covering Fire disrupts attention and space control.

Summary for New Players

If you are unsure what to do:

- If enemies are approaching -> **You are already in Default Guard**
- If attacked -> **Dodge, Parry, or Block**
- If you want to hit something -> **Attack**
- If you want to hit hard -> **Full Martial Attack**
- If you want to close distance -> **Advance**

The system assumes competence.
You only need to think harder when you choose to.

Advanced combat options, custom RHLF assemblies, and special feats are covered in later sections.

Range & Guard

Combat in the 24-System is resolved using **range states** and **Guard**, not measurements or grids.
Range determines what actions are possible, while Guard determines whether movement is contested.

Range States

All combatants exist in one of three range states relative to one another:

- **Separated**
  - No physical contact
  - Ranged weapons and reach dominate
- **Melee**
  - Weapon-length engagement
  - Most conventional fighting occurs here
- **Grappling**
  - Bodies entangled
  - Limb control and leverage dominate

Range is categorical, not spatial. Characters do not track distance, only relative range state.

Guard (Space Control)

Guard represents actively threatening space or waiting on a specific trigger.

Default Guard (Unspoken)

- A character who is **aware** and **not engaged** is automatically in Default Guard.
- Default Guard requires no declaration and no action.

Triggered Action (Spoken)

- On your turn, you may declare a specific trigger and response.
- You must state:
  - Trigger (what event causes the response)
  - Response (what you do when triggered)
  - Required anchors committed (`L`, `R`, `H`, `F`) and any ammo/stamina costs
- Trigger language matters:
  - The trigger resolves exactly as declared.
  - If the declared condition happens, the response fires, even if the outcome is now undesirable.
  - Broader wording creates broader risk.
- Trigger examples:
  - "If something enters, I shoot it." -> triggers on **any** entry.
  - "If a man in a purple hat enters, I shoot him." -> triggers only on that specific condition.
- If the trigger occurs before your next turn, resolve the response immediately.
- If you abort after the trigger event occurs, roll `2d12` to resolve the shot.
  - On a hit, choose one:
    - Deal damage normally, or
    - Deal no damage and take a **Minor Complication** instead.
- If the trigger does not occur, the declaration expires at the start of your next turn.
- Triggered Action does not change initiative order.

Direction and Scope

- Guard is **directional** and **attention-limited**.
- By default, a character may cover **one approach**.

Engagement

- A character is **engaged** when an enemy is in Melee or Grappling range with them.
- Once engaged, a character **cannot maintain Guard against additional advances** unless a special ability allows it.

Weapon Interaction with Guard

- **Reach Weapons** (spears, polearms):
  - May contest advances from **Separated -> Melee**
  - May contest advances from **Melee -> Grappling**
  - May contest **Move-By attempts**
- **Non-Reach Melee Weapons** (swords, axes, maces):
  - May contest advances from **Melee -> Grappling**
  - May contest **Move-By attempts**
  - Do **not** contest Separated -> Melee
- **Unarmed or Improvised Weapons**:
  - Cannot contest advances through Guard

Advancing Range

To move closer to an enemy, a character must attempt an **Advance**.

- Advancing **toward or past** an opponent with Guard is a contested action.
- Advancing **away** from an opponent is safe unless surrounded or restrained.

The advancing character typically rolls **Athletics**.
The difficulty is set by the defender's Guard strength, weapon, and situation.

Multiple Guards

Multiple defenders may combine their Guard against a single advancing target.

- The first guard sets the base difficulty.
- Each additional guard increases the difficulty by **+2**.

Example:
Four characters covering the same approach:
DC = Base + 2 x (4 - 1)

Failure Against Multiple Guards

- On a failed advance, **one guard of the defenders' choice** resolves the consequence.
- This prevents stacking damage while preserving group control.

Once an advance is resolved, Guard does **not** persist against subsequent advances in the same moment.

Attention and Guard (The Head - H)

Guard requires **attention**, represented by the **Head (H)**.

Actions That Break Guard

Any action that meaningfully commits the Head breaks Guard against other threats until the character's next turn. Examples include:

- Making an attack
- Aiming and firing at a specific target
- Casting a spell
- Searching or tracking
- Issuing complex commands
- Reacting to a different threat

Actions That Do NOT Break Guard

Actions that do not require conscious focus do not break Guard, including:

- Walking or repositioning
- Backing away
- Raising a shield
- Drawing or stowing a weapon
- Routine reloads
- Blind manipulation of equipment

Magic is inherently dangerous; **all spellcasting requires H** and breaks Guard.

Voluntarily Dropping Guard

A character may voluntarily drop Guard at any time by committing their Head (H) to another task.
This requires no action and no roll.

Covering Fire

Covering Fire is a deliberate attempt to disrupt an enemy's attention and space control.

Requirements

- Requires: `LH`
- Expends ammo

Effect

- Does **not** deal damage
- Select one enemy:
  - That enemy **loses Guard** until the start of their next turn

Covering Fire represents suppression, distraction, and forcing an opponent to seek cover.
Using Covering Fire breaks the user's own Guard.

Design Notes

- Guard is a **state**, not a passive aura
- Attention is a scarce resource
- Packs and flanking are dangerous by default
- Weapon choice meaningfully shapes space control
- Ranged and melee Guard follow the same rules

Range control emerges naturally from intent, positioning, and commitment.

Guard (Refined Resolution)

When a character attempts to advance against an opponent with Guard and **fails**, the advancing character must choose one of the following outcomes:

- **Stop:**
  The advance fails and the character remains at their current range.
- **Push Through:**
  The character completes the advance but suffers the Guard attack or consequence.

Critical Failure

On a **Critical Failure**, both outcomes occur:

- The advance fails
- The character also suffers the Guard attack or consequence

This represents reckless commitment, loss of footing, or overextension into danger.

Covering Fire (Refined Resolution)

Covering Fire represents suppressive or distracting fire intended to disrupt an enemy's space control.

Resolution

When Covering Fire succeeds against an opponent with Guard, the defender must choose one:

- **Take Cover:**
  The defender loses Guard until the start of their next turn.
- **Stand Fast:**
  The defender maintains Guard but suffers the covering fire attack.

Partial Critical

On a **Partial Critical**, both outcomes occur:

- The defender loses Guard
- The defender also suffers the attack

Covering Fire always expends ammo and always breaks the user's own Guard.

Design Intent

- Guard forces hard choices, not automatic damage
- Covering Fire mirrors Guard through attention pressure
- Partial Criticals escalate outcomes without adding conditions
- Critical Failures punish overcommitment, not mere bad luck

Defense Actions (24-System)

When attacked, a defender may choose how to respond. Defense is an **active choice**, not a passive number. Each defense option changes the attacker's Difficulty Class (DC) and how damage is resolved.

A character may only use a defense that relies on a limb they have not already committed this round.

Base Defense (No Active Defense)

If the defender does nothing special:

- **Attack DC = 13**
- On a hit, damage is applied normally.

This represents the baseline difficulty of striking a moving, aware target in combat.

Parry (Skill-Based Avoidance)

Skill Used: Melee
Concept: Weapon skill, timing, redirection

Effect:

- **Parry DC = Average of defender's Melee roll**
- The attack must meet or exceed this DC to hit.

On a Hit:

- Damage is **deflected**, not avoided.
- Reduce or redirect damage (GM discretion):
  - −1 wound
  - Damage shifted to weapon or armor integrity
  - Loss of balance or position

Costs & Risks:

- No stamina cost
- On Partial Crit or Legendary against a parry:
  - Defender's weapon may lose integrity
  - Parry may partially fail

Parry represents skillful interference with the attack, not absorbing force.

Dodge (Movement-Based Avoidance)

Skill Used: Athletics
Concept: Getting out of the way entirely

Effect:

- **Dodge DC = Average of defender's Athletics roll**
- If the attack fails to meet the DC, **all damage is avoided**.

Cost:

- Dodge **always costs stamina**, whether successful or not.
- On failure, stamina is spent and damage is taken.

Notes:

- Dodge is the only defense that fully negates damage.
- Repeated dodging leads quickly to exhaustion and disadvantage.

Block (Interception, Not Avoidance)

Concept: Putting something solid in the way

Attack DC: 13 (unchanged)

Blocking does **not** make you harder to hit. Instead, it changes *what* is hit.

On a Hit:

- Damage is absorbed and converted to stamina loss, similar to armor.
- The block may cause integrity loss to the blocking item.

Blocking With a Shield

Shields provide superior protection.

Shield Benefit:

- The **first wound** from a blocked hit is absorbed **for free**
- This first wound costs **no stamina**
- Additional wounds convert to stamina as normal

Shields do not avoid hits, but they dramatically reduce consequences.

Blocking cover

Blocking Without a Shield

Blocking with an arm,

- No free mitigation
- All damage dealt is to the interposing limb up to its disabled mark. Excess damage translates to the intended target.

This represents desperate or improvised defense.

Defense Summary Table

Defense	DC	Avoids Hit?	Damage Handling	Cost
None	13	No	Full damage	—
Parry	Avg Melee	Partial	Deflect / reduce	Integrity risk
Dodge	Avg Athletics	Yes	None on success	Stamina
Block (shield)	13	No	First wound free, rest stamina	None (first wound)

Design Notes

- **Parry** rewards skill and timing.
- **Dodge** trades safety for exhaustion.
- **Block** accepts the hit to control its consequences.
- **Shields** are powerful but do not replace armor or movement.
- Heavy weapons pressure blocks; multiple attackers overwhelm parries.

Defense is about choices under pressure, not static numbers.

Cover & Concealment (24-System)

Cover and concealment represent environmental factors that interfere with attacks. They modify the **attack DC** or change how damage is resolved, depending on the situation.

Cover and concealment stack with active defenses (Block, Parry, Dodge) unless stated otherwise.

Concealment

Concealment interferes with perception but does not physically stop attacks.

Examples:

- Smoke, fog, darkness
- Foliage, tall grass
- Visual clutter or partial obscuration

Ranged Attacks

- **+1 DC** to the attack roll

Melee Attacks

- Concealment usually has **no effect** in melee.
- Concealment applies in melee only if it meaningfully interferes with awareness or movement (GM discretion), such as:
  - Pitch darkness
  - Blinding smoke
  - Deep water or heavy mud

When applicable:

- **+1 DC**

Concealment never absorbs damage.

Cover

Cover physically interposes something between attacker and defender. How it works depends on whether the attack is **ranged** or **melee**, and on the type of cover used.

Ranged Cover

Cover affects ranged attacks by making the target harder to hit.

Passive Cover Cover exists, but the defender is not actively positioning behind it.

Examples:

- Door frames
- Furniture
- Low walls
- Vehicles

Effect:

- **+1 DC**

Active Cover (Using Legs – L) The defender deliberately positions themselves behind cover.

Requirements:

- Commit **Legs (L)** for the round

Effect:

- **+2 DC**

If the defender moves or is forced out of position, active cover is lost.

Melee Cover

In melee, cover works differently. Cover only helps if it is actively used.

Interposed Objects (Tables, Doors, Carts, Shields) These function like blocking.

Requirements:

- Commit **one arm (L or R)**

Effect:

- Attack DC is unchanged
- Damage is absorbed or converted, as with a block
- The object may lose integrity or break

Notes:

- Shields absorb the first wound for free (no stamina cost)
- Other objects convert wounds to stamina and risk integrity loss

If no arm is committed:

- The object provides **no benefit** against melee attacks

Structural Cover (Walls, Corners, Pillars) Structural cover provides protection through positioning, not interception.

Requirements:

- Commit **Legs (L)** to maintain position

Effect:

- **+1 DC** against melee attacks
- Structural cover does **not** absorb damage
- No arm is required

This represents controlling angles, footing, and approach lanes.

Total Cover If the structure fully blocks access:

- The attack **cannot be made**
- The attacker must reposition, grapple, force the defender out, or attack the structure

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Stacking Cover with Defense

Cover and concealment stack with active defenses.

Examples:

- Ranged attack against a dodging target in active cover:
  - Base DC 13
  - +2 DC (active cover)
  - +Athletics DC (Dodge)

- Melee attack against a defender pressed into a corner and parrying:
  - Base DC 13
  - +1 DC (structural cover)
  - +Melee DC (Parry)

Design Notes

- Concealment affects perception, not force.
- Cover at range avoids hits; cover in melee controls consequences.
- Objects are blocked with arms; structures are leveraged with legs.
- Cover buys time, not safety.

Positioning matters. Choices matter. Terrain matters.

Movement (Playtest Rules)

Movement Rate (MR)

- Base MR for an unencumbered human: **6**
- MR is the maximum distance moved using one **Leg action**
- MR cannot drop below **1** unless immobilized

Armor & Packs

Apply **only the single worst penalty** from armor or pack.

Armor

- No / Light: no penalty
- Medium: −1 MR
- Heavy: −2 MR

Packs

- No / Light Pack: no penalty
- Medium Pack: −1 MR
- Heavy Pack: −2 MR

Heavy Pack Restrictions

- A pack may be doffed as a **Hand action**
- While wearing a **Heavy Pack**:
  - You cannot **sprint**, **leap**, or perform **acrobatic movement**
  - MR penalties still follow the non-stacking rule

Using Movement

- Spending your **Leg action** allows movement up to MR
- Movement may be split before or after other actions
- An unused Leg action counts as unused defense
- Normal movement/reposition still allows **Dodge** as a reaction this round

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Sprinting

- Spend **1 stamina** to gain **+2 MR** for that movement
- Sprinting is not allowed while wearing a **Heavy Pack**
- Sprinting may be used only during your own turn
- If you Sprint, you cannot Dodge until your next turn (unless a trait says otherwise)

Engagement & Movement

- You **cannot freely move** while adjacent to an enemy
- Attempting to do so allows the enemy to spend a **defense action**
- To avoid this, you must use an **action skill** (e.g. shove, tumble, feint)
  - These are not movement and are resolved separately

Dangerous Terrain

- Dangerous terrain requires an **Athletics check** to traverse safely
- DC is set by the substance or hazard
- Failure may result in falling, slipping, or other consequences

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Difficult Terrain

- Difficult terrain reduces MR or forces a Dangerous Terrain check
- Effects are determined by the environment

Injuries

- Each **leg injury** reduces MR by **1**
- Effects are cumulative

Crits During Movement

- **Partial Crit:** You may ignore enemy defense actions during the movement
- **Double Crit:** Same effect, but you look extremely impressive
- Crits do not increase distance or negate terrain consequences

Movement Techniques

While using your **Leg action** for movement, you may incorporate any of the following as part of the same movement:

- **Tumble**
- **Leap**
- **Sprint**
- **Navigate terrain**
- **Move stealthily**

These do not require separate actions, but may:

- Trigger **contested rolls**,
- Require **Athletics or Stealth checks**,
- Provoke **defense actions** if performed while adjacent to enemies,
- Be restricted by armor, packs, injuries, or terrain.

The Leg action represents continuous body movement, not a single step.

Dodge Availability by Footwork

- **Move/Reposition only:** Dodge remains available.
- **Sprint or Leap used:** Dodge is unavailable until your next turn.
- Traits may override this (for example, **Acrobatic Finesse**).

Weapons & Weapon Properties

In the 24-System, weapons are defined less by abstract damage types and more by **how they apply pressure** in combat.

All weapons follow the same base rules for attacking, wounds, armor, stamina, and range.
Weapons feel different because of their **properties**, especially what happens on a **Partial Critical**.

Weapon Categories (Baseline)

Weapons are broadly categorized by how many hands they require and how many wounds they deal.

- **One-Handed Weapons**

  - Require: `L`
  - Deal: **1 wound**
- **Two-Handed Weapons**
  - Require: `L(R)`
  - Deal: **2 wounds**

This establishes the baseline risk–reward tradeoff: greater commitment produces greater harm, but is harder to sustain when injured or fatigued.

Weapon Properties

Each weapon has **at most one Primary Property** and may have additional **Qualities**.

Primary Properties

Primary properties define what a weapon does on a **Partial Critical**.
A weapon may only have **one** primary property.

Precision

Daggers, rapiers, stilettos, bayonets

Partial Critical Effect

- Inflict **Bleed 1**
- Bleed is resolved as **immediate stamina loss**
- This stamina loss **ignores armor conversion**
- Armor does **not** lose integrity from this effect

Fiction

- Weak points
- Gaps in armor
- Shock, blood loss, or disrupted breathing

Precision weapons excel at exhausting or destabilizing opponents rather than breaking armor.

Chopping

Axes, cleavers, heavy blades

Partial Critical Effect

- Target armor loses **+2 integrity** instead of the normal +1

Fiction

- Edge bites
- Structural damage
- Repeated stress fractures in armor

Chopping weapons are excellent at destroying protection, but less subtle than precision weapons.

Crushing

Maces, hammers, mauls

Partial Critical Effect

- **Ignore one level of mitigation**
  - Armor converts one fewer wound to stamina
  - Or cannot fully absorb the blow

Fiction

- Concussive force
- Broken bones beneath armor
- Internal trauma

Crushing weapons punish heavy armor without needing to destroy it.

Weapon Qualities

Qualities modify how a weapon behaves, but do not change its Partial Critical effect.

A weapon may have multiple qualities.

Reach

- Weapon may **ward advances** from **Separated → Melee**
- Weapon may also ward **Melee → Grappling** and **Move-By attempts**
- Reach increases the difficulty of advancing past the wielder
- Reach weapons lose most advantages once grappling occurs

Typical reach weapons:

- Spears
- Polearms
- Pikes

Parry

- Weapon may **attack while maintaining a prepared defense**
- Represents binding, redirection, and controlled engagement
- Common on swords and well-balanced polearms

Parry weapons favor control and survivability over raw damage.

Brace

- Weapon gains benefits when set against a charge or advance
- Often increases warding effectiveness
- Common on spears, polearms, and bayonets

Improvised

- Weapon is usable in unfavorable ranges or conditions
- Loses primary property
- Deals reduced damage
- Examples:
  - Haft strikes
  - Pommel strikes
  - Butt-end shoves

Range Interaction Summary

Weapons interact with range through **warding**, not abstract distances.

- **Reach Weapons**
  - Ward Separated → Melee
  - Ward Melee → Grappling
- **Non-Reach Melee Weapons**
  - Ward Melee → Grappling only
- **Unarmed / Improvised**
  - Cannot ward advances

Backing away from an opponent is generally safe unless surrounded or restrained.

Design Notes

- Weapons differ by **pressure profile**, not damage type
- Partial Critical effects create identity without added bookkeeping
- Armor remains meaningful without becoming absolute
- Injury, fatigue, and positioning naturally reshape weapon effectiveness over time

Weapon choice is tactical, situational, and narrative—not merely numeric.

Specific weapon examples and stat blocks are provided in later sections.

Example Weapons

Weapon	Hands	Wounds	Primary Property	Qualities	Notes
Dagger	L	1	Precision	—	Excels at grappling range
Rapier	L	1	Precision	Parry	Dueling weapon
Sword	L	1	—	Parry	Balanced, defensive
Greatsword	L(R)	2	—	Parry	High commitment
Axe	L	1	Chopping	—	Destroys armor
Greataxe	L(R)	2	Chopping	—	Anti-armor brute
Mace	L	1	Crushing	—	Punishes heavy armor
Maul	L(R)	2	Crushing	—	Breaks through mitigation
Spear	L(R)	1–2	—	Reach, Brace	Superior space control
Pike	L(R)	2	—	Reach, Brace	Formation weapon
Bow	L(R)	1	Precision	—	Separated range only
Firearm	L(R)	1–2	Precision	—	Wards space, ammo-limited

Ranged Weapons – Action Economy & Tactical Role (24-System)

This table summarizes how each ranged weapon interacts with the **limb-based action economy**, followed by short design notes explaining *why each weapon exists* in play.

Ranged Weapon Action Economy

Weapon	Fire Limbs Used	Reload Limbs Used	Preloaded?	Indoor Use	Noise	Notes
Sling	1 Arm	Other Arm	No	Yes	Silent	Most f
Short Bow	2 Arms	Included in attack	No	Yes	Silent	Compa
Long Bow	2 Arms	Included in attack	No	Poor	Silent	Requir

Weapon	Fire Limbs Used	Reload Limbs Used	Preloaded?	Indoor Use	Noise	Notes
Crossbow (Light)	1 Arm	2 Arms (+legs optional)	Yes	Yes	Quiet	Ambus
Crossbow (Heavy)	2 Arms	2 Arms + Legs	Yes	Poor	Quiet	High s
Pistol	1 Arm	2 Arms	Yes	Yes	Loud	Emerg
Rifle	2 Arms	2 Arms	Yes	Poor	Loud	Decisiv

Weapon Explanations

Sling

- Fired with one arm, reloaded with the other.
- Can be used while injured, climbing, or defending.
- Lowest lethality, but highest flexibility.
- Ideal for harassment, hunting, and sustained skirmishing.
- Silent and cheap, but weak against armor unless crits occur.

Design Role:
The sling is the *most ergonomic* ranged weapon, not the most deadly.

Short Bow

- Requires both arms to fire.
- Drawing an arrow is part of the attack action.
- Compact enough for indoor or tight environments.
- Quiet, sustainable, and reliable.

Design Role:
A balanced, mobile ranged weapon for scouts and skirmishers.

Long Bow

- Requires both arms and space to operate.
- Awkward or disadvantaged indoors.
- Excellent at warding space at Separated range.
- Strong sustained pressure, but vulnerable to injury or crowding.

Design Role:
The long bow rewards preparation and positioning.

Crossbow (Light)

- May be carried cocked and loaded.
- Can be fired one-handed, but reload requires both arms.
- Reloading under pressure is difficult.
- Quiet, accurate, and lethal on the opening shot.

Design Role:
An ambush weapon, not a sustained combat tool.

Crossbow (Heavy)

- Requires both arms to fire.
- Reloading requires full-body commitment (arms + legs).
- Very slow under combat conditions.
- Often unusable once enemies close.

Design Role:
A pre-planned, high-risk opening weapon.

Pistol

- Fired with one arm.
- Reloading requires both arms and time.
- Loud, ammo-limited, but usable while moving or wounded.
- Crits can be immediately decisive.

Design Role:
A panic button and finisher, not a primary solution.

Rifle

- Requires both arms to fire and reload.
- Awkward in confined spaces.
- Loud and attention-drawing.
- Crits cause catastrophic outcomes.

Design Role:
A fight-ending weapon used only when escalation is acceptable.

Design Summary

- **Bows and guns are parity weapons until crits.**

- **Crits unlock armor bypass and trauma.**
- **Reload friction and limb commitment are the real balancing factors.**
- **Melee dominates chaos; ranged dominates preparation.**

This keeps firearms rare, terrifying, and never casually optimal.

Wounds, Trauma, and Disability (24-System)

Wounds represent lasting physical trauma. Unlike stamina, wounds do not recover quickly and have escalating consequences. Wounds are tracked by body region and progress through defined states.

Wound States

All body regions follow the same basic wound ladder:

OK → Injured → Disabled → Missing

Each additional wound to the same region advances it one step along this ladder.

Body Regions & Wound Tracks

Arms (Left / Right)

Each arm tracks wounds independently.

Wounds	State	Effect
0	OK	Full use
1	Injured	Pain, impaired fine control
2	Disabled	Arm unusable for attacks, blocking, warding, or two-handed actions
3	Missing	Arm destroyed or severed

Notes:

- If either arm is Disabled, two-handed weapons cannot be used.
- A second Disabled arm leaves the character effectively unarmed.

Head (Special Case)

The head has unique consequences.

Wounds	State	Effect
0	OK	No effect
1	Injured	Stunned, disoriented, fear spike
2	Sensory Damage	Blindness, deafness, or severe impairment (GM chooses)
3	Unconscious	Immediate loss of consciousness

Notes:

- Head wounds are never instantly fatal by default.
- Further head trauma after unconsciousness causes Core damage.

Legs (Shared Track)

Legs use a shared wound pool representing both legs together.

Wounds	State	Effect
0	OK	Normal movement
1–2	Injured	Reduced speed, harder dodges
3–4	Disabled	Cannot run, dodge, or stand unaided
5–6	Missing	One or both legs destroyed

Notes:

- Disabled legs reduce the character to crawling or immobility.
- Missing legs usually cause severe bleeding (see Core Wounds).

Core (Torso / Vital Mass)

The core represents vital organs and systemic trauma.

Core Wounds	Condition
0–2	Wounded
3–4	Failing
5	Dying
6	Dead

Notes:

- Core wounds may come from direct hits, spillover, bleeding, or massive trauma.

- Reaching 6 Core wounds results in death.

Armor and Wounds

Armor is worn as a **single unit**, not by location.

Armor converts wounds to stamina loss when hit.

Armor Type	Wounds Converted per Hit
Light	1
Medium	2
Heavy	3

Rules:

- Armor converts wounds **before** they are applied to a body region.
- Excess wounds beyond the armor's conversion capacity are suffered as normal wounds.
- Armor does not prevent disabling or missing limbs once its capacity is exceeded.
- Armor may lose integrity or effectiveness based on attack results (Partial Crits, Legendary results, Breaker weapons, etc.).

Medical Care & Recovery

- **Injured**: Can recover with rest and basic medical attention.
- **Disabled**: Requires significant treatment, splinting, or surgery.
- **Missing**: Permanent without extraordinary intervention.
- **Core wounds**: Require urgent care; failure to stabilize may result in death.

The Guide determines recovery time and consequences based on fiction, resources, and severity.

Fear Track (24-System)

Fear represents acute stress, dread, and cognitive overload.
It is **situational and temporary**, but repeated extreme fear leaves lasting scars.

Fear is tracked in **levels from 0 to 6**.

Fear usually rises from:

- Witnessing overwhelming horror

- Being hunted, cornered, or helpless
- Near-death experiences
- Supernatural or existential violations

Fear usually falls through:

- Distance from the threat
- Shelter or safety
- Time, rest, reassurance
- Successful escape or containment

Fear Levels

Fear 0 — Steady

You are calm, focused, and in control.

- No mechanical effects
- Full access to all RLHF components

Fear 1 — Unease

Something is wrong. You feel alert, but not panicked.

Effects:

- +1 Initiative when surprised or ambushed (hypervigilance)
- No penalties

Narrative cues:

- Restlessness
- Scanning exits
- Quiet tension

Fear 2 — Tension

The threat feels real and close.

Effects:

- Disadvantage on reckless or impulsive actions
- Advantage on preparation, observation, and warding

Narrative cues:

- Short replies
- Tight grip on gear

- Growing urgency

Fear 3 — Strain

Your body begins prioritizing survival over intent.

Effects:

- Hesitation when **advancing toward danger**
- Hesitation does not apply when retreating or bracing

Narrative cues:

- Pauses before acting
- Arguments to delay or withdraw
- Fixation on escape routes

Fear 4 — Panic

Cognitive load overwhelms fine control.

Effects:

- Hesitation applies to **all hostile engagement**
- First aggressive action each scene loses one RLHF component
- Defensive and evasive actions are unaffected

Narrative cues:

- Shaking hands
- Tunnel vision
- Breathing control issues

Fear 5 — Overwhelm

The body begins to shut down nonessential functions.

Effects:

- You may only use **3 of 4 RLHF components each turn**
- GM may restrict especially reckless choices
- Cannot initiate complex or coordinated plans under pressure

Narrative cues:

- Freezing
- Automatic reactions
- Reliance on others' direction

Fear 6 — Breakdown

Your system fails to cope.

Effects:

- Immediate loss of consciousness **or**
- Total withdrawal (curl, flee blindly, collapse), GM adjudicates
- If caused by supernatural or lethal horror, this may create a **lasting Bane or Survivor Resonance**

Narrative cues:

- Blackout
- Dissociation
- Complete surrender to instinct

Fear Recovery

Fear is not permanent.

Fear may be reduced by:

- Leaving the danger zone
- Reaching shelter or safety
- Time without threat
- Reassurance from allies
- Clear evidence the threat is gone

Typical recovery:

- −1 Fear level per scene of safety
- Faster recovery with preparation, control, or success

Fear and Madness

Fear is temporary.
Madness is cumulative.

Fear causes **Hesitation**.
Madness emerges when Banes accumulate and Hesitation becomes frequent.

Fear asks:

> "What do you do right now?"

Madness answers:

> "What can you no longer make yourself do?"

Design Notes

- Fear penalizes **entering danger**, not survival
- Fear rewards caution, preparation, and withdrawal
- Fear never removes agency outright
- Madness emerges naturally if characters survive too long

Fear is the pressure.
Madness is the shape left behind.

Emergent Madness: A Design Note

This system does not include a traditional "madness meter."

Instead, **madness emerges naturally from accumulated survival scars**.

Core Principle

Madness is not the loss of control.
Madness is the **loss of authorship**.

A character is not insane when they act randomly or irrationally.
A character becomes mad when **the world increasingly decides for them**.

How Madness Emerges

Each near-death encounter may leave behind a **Bane**:

- Hesitation in specific situations
- Loss of access to one RLHF component at critical moments
- Automatic caution, withdrawal, or fixation

Each Bane is:

- Contextual, not global
- Earned through survival
- Tied to a specific horror or lethal force

Over time, these Banes accumulate.

No single scar removes agency.
But together, they **narrow the space of viable choices**.

The character still chooses, but fewer choices remain available.

Fear vs. Madness

- **Fear** is acute and situational
  It biases behavior in the moment.
- **Madness** is cumulative and structural
  It is the long-term consequence of repeatedly surviving what should not be survived.

Fear asks: *"What do you do right now?"*
Madness answers: *"What can you no longer bring yourself to do?"*

The Shift in Causality

Early in a campaign:

- The player acts
- The world responds

Late in a campaign:

- The world threatens
- The player responds

No switch is flipped.
No condition is declared.

The order of causality quietly reverses.

Why This Matters

- Player agency is never removed outright
- Madness feels inevitable, not punitive
- Veterans survive longer, but act with increasing restraint
- Caution replaces initiative
- Reaction replaces intention

Madness is not imposed by a table or a roll.

Madness is what remains when survival becomes the only reliable action.

Design Summary

- Madness is emergent, not tracked
- Survival teaches lessons that cannot be unlearned
- The world gains veto power one narrow context at a time

- Those who survive the longest are the most constrained

Not because they are weak.

Because they have learned too much.

Status Effects

Status effects are temporary or scene-level conditions that change what a character can do. They stack with wounds, fear, and pressure unless a rule says otherwise.

Use this format:

- **How it starts**
- **Effect**
- **How it ends**

Poison and disease are intentionally excluded here and handled separately.

Blind

How it starts

- No functional visual targeting (darkness, smoke, sensory damage, blindfold, etc.).

Effect

- Apply blind action penalties by task type:
  - `+2 DC`: gross movement on known ground (short move, simple footing check).
  - `+4 DC`: contact/precision actions (strike, grapple, disarm, called placement, lock manipulation).
  - `+6 DC` or disallow: high-risk navigation (long leap, unstable climb, hazard crossing).
- Guide chooses the nearest category by fiction.

How it ends

- Visual targeting is restored, or another valid sense/ability explicitly replaces sight.

Prone

How it starts

- Knockdown, failed footing, throw, blast force, or voluntary drop.

Effect

- Speed is `0` until you stand.
- Melee attacks against you gain one advantage step (see `core.md` Advantage Step Rule).
- Your melee attacks while prone take `+2 DC` unless using an explicit prone-capable action.
- You cannot use Dodge actions that require full footwork.

How it ends

- Spend a movement action to stand (requires usable `F` and no status preventing rise).

Grabbed

How it starts

- At least one anchor (`L`, `R`, `F`, or `H`) is restrained by a grapple lock.

Effect

- Speed is `0`.
- Restrained anchors cannot be used except to attempt `Break Free`.
- If you have no active lock on your grappler and act without `H`, use Blind penalties as appropriate.

How it ends

- Remove all locks affecting you (usually via `Break Free`, forced separation, or grappler release).

Pinned

How it starts

- Three of your anchors are restrained.

Effect

- You are fully restrained.
- Your remaining unrestrained anchor is treated as unusable.
- You cannot move, stand, advance, or reposition.
- You may only attempt `Break Free` or other explicitly allowed minimal actions.

How it ends

- Reduce restraints to fewer than three anchors.

Restrained

How it starts

- Environmental bindings, tools (cuffs/rope), or effects that physically limit action.

Effect

- Speed is `0` unless the restraint explicitly allows partial movement.
- Any anchor bound by restraint cannot be used for normal actions.
- Actions requiring bound anchors are unavailable until freed.

How it ends

- Break, pick, cut, or otherwise remove the restraint.

Disoriented

How it starts

- Head trauma, flash effects, violent motion, fear spikes, or sensory overload.

Effect

- `+2 DC` to actions requiring precise targeting, planning, or rapid reassessment.
- You cannot take Triggered Actions that depend on fine identity discrimination unless you first re-acquire target certainty.

How it ends

- End of next turn by default, or earlier with successful stabilization/recovery effect.

Stunned

How it starts

- Severe impact, electrical shock, concussion effect, or major interruption.

Effect

- Lose your next declared action.
- You may still take minimal reflexive defense if an anchor is available.

How it ends

- After the skipped action resolves.

Silenced

How it starts

- Gagged, choking hold, vacuum/no air, magical suppression, or severe throat trauma.

Effect

- Cannot perform speech-dependent actions (many Social actions, verbal spell components, clear command calls).
- Nonverbal actions are unaffected unless other anchors are also constrained.

How it ends

- Airway/speech pathway restored.

Incapacitated

How it starts

- Collapse, extreme trauma, unconsciousness, shock, or explicit effect.

Effect

- Cannot take voluntary actions.
- Cannot maintain Guard, Triggered Actions, or active defenses.
- Usually treated as defenseless in direct conflict.

How it ends

- Stabilization, recovery, or external intervention returns functional action capacity.

Unconscious

How it starts

- Usually from severe head/core trauma or sedation.

Effect

- You are Incapacitated and unaware.
- Cannot defend, move, speak, or perform checks.

How it ends

- Wake by medical intervention, recovery, or fiction-appropriate trigger.

Bleeding

How it starts

- Open trauma judged by the Guide as ongoing blood loss.

Effect

- At end of your turn, take escalating pressure or 1 progress toward additional harm (Guide chooses model for scene).
- Strenuous actions while bleeding may add `+2 DC`.

How it ends

- Bleeding is staunched (first aid, compression, cauterization, or equivalent effect).

Priority Rule

If multiple status effects conflict:

1. The most restrictive action limit applies.
2. Apply the highest DC increase from statuses that affect the same action.
3. If two effects both set speed, use the lower speed.

Character Creation (24-System)

Welcome to the **24-System**. Character creation is fast, flexible, and focused on what your character can do, not on abstract attributes.

There are no Strength, Dexterity, or Intelligence scores. Your skills, traits, and decisions define your character.

Step 1: Describe Your Character

Before assigning mechanics, describe who your character is.

- Name
- Age
- Appearance
- Background
- Personality
- Motivation

There are no restrictions on body type, upbringing, or origin. Descriptors are narrative, not mechanical.

Step 2: Assign Your Skills

Skills determine the dice you roll for risky or dramatic actions.

Core Skills

Choose from:

- **Athletics** - climbing, running, swimming, physical exertion
- **Melee** - close combat, weapon control, grappling
- **Ranged** - aimed attacks, suppressive fire, reload discipline
- **Thievery** - stealth, lockpicking, covert manipulation
- **Lore** - knowledge, pattern recognition, threat analysis
- **Science** - medicine, engineering, chemistry, analysis
- **Social** - persuasion, deception, intimidation, command
- **Magic** - casting, wards, counters, rituals

Skill Dice Assignment

Assign four skills at creation:

- **1 Specialty Skill** `d8 + d10 + 6` (Rank 3)
- **1 Strong Skill** `2d10 + 4` (Rank 2)
- **2 Competent Skills** `d10 + d12 + 2` (Rank 1)

All other skills are unassigned and use the vanilla roll:

`2d12` (Rank 0)

Example

Jael the Exile, a clever rogue:

- Thievery: `d8 + d10 + 6` (specialty)
- Social: `2d10 + 4` (strong)
- Athletics: `d10 + d12 + 2` (competent)
- Lore: `d10 + d12 + 2` (competent)

Melee, Ranged, Science, Magic are unassigned and use `2d12`.

Step 3: Choose Traits

Traits define how your character approaches danger, survival, and problem-solving.

Choose **2 traits** from any categories below.

Rules language note:

- When a trait says "gain one advantage step," use `core.md` Advantage Step Rule.
- Traits that mention reaction exceptions explicitly override the default reaction commitment rule.

Martial and Survivor Traits

- **Strong Back** - Carry 1 extra Large item without penalty.
- **Weapon Familiarity** - Choose one weapon type; gain one advantage step when using it.
- **Shield-Bearer** - You may shove or bash with a shield and still use `R` to Block once this round.
- **Tireless Runner** - Sprint and jog distance before stamina loss is doubled.
- **Elite Athlete** - Choose running, climbing, or swimming; increase distance by 50%.
- **Pack Fighter** - Gain one advantage step when adjacent to an ally attacking the same target.
- **Tough** - First time you are wounded in a combat, reduce that wound by 1.
- **Quick Draw** - Ready a weapon and attack in the same action.
- **Guarded Swing** - Once per round, if you used `L` for an attack on your turn, you may still Parry with `L`.
- **Acrobatic Finesse** - If you used `Sprint` or `Leap` this turn, you may still Dodge as a reaction..

Social and Leadership Traits

- **Silver Tongue** - Once per scene, reroll a failed Social check.
- **Inspiring Presence** - Allies within earshot gain one advantage step vs fear or fatigue checks.
- **Streetwise** - Gain minor hints or rumors when asking NPCs.
- **Menacing** - On a successful Intimidate, target hesitates for one round before acting aggressively.

Survivalist and Explorer Traits

- **Keen Senses** - Guide always provides one extra environmental clue when you search.
- **Forager** - Once per day, find enough food and water for yourself.

- **Toughened** - Reduce stamina damage from environmental hazards by 1.
- **Pathfinder** - Wilderness travel time is reduced by one tier.
- **Trapwise** - You always notice at least one clue that a nearby trap exists.

Mystic and Lore Traits

- **Arcane Sensitivity** - You sense nearby magic, even faint traces.
- **Ritual Memory** - Perform one simple ritual per day without materials.
- **Scholar of the Old World** - Gain one advantage step on Lore checks about pre-disaster knowledge.
- **Dream-Touched** - Guide provides vague prophetic fragments during sleep.
- **Talisman-Bearer** - Once per session, negate a Minor Complication.

Rogue and Trickster Traits

- **Quick Fingers** - Automatic success on simple locks or simple traps under low pressure.
- **Shadowstep** - Gain one advantage step on Thievery in low light.
- **Evasive** - First hit per combat deals one fewer wound.
- **Deceptive Feint** - On a miss, target suffers `+2 DC` on its next attack against you this round.
- **Light Foot** - Ignore minor encumbrance penalties while sneaking or climbing.
- **Skulker** - Ignore low-light penalties and reduce no-light penalties by one step for Thievery actions.

Dark and Gritty Survival Traits

- **Scarred Survivor** - After a Major Complication, gain one advantage step on your next action.
- **Desperate Strength** - When at negative stamina, your first successful attack in a scene gains +1 wound.
- **Grim Reputation** - Gain one advantage step on Intimidate; suffer `+2 DC` on Persuade against neutral or friendly targets.
- **Bloodied but Unbowed** - First wound in combat causes you to gain 1 stamina.

Step 4: Equipment and Talents

For now, note any:

- distinctive gear
- personal items
- learned tricks
- narrative talents

Examples:

- Old family sword
- Lockpicks
- Silver signet ring
- Crowbar and rope

Full equipment rules are covered elsewhere.

Step 5: Final Touches

Complete your character:

- Name
- Appearance and Background (1-2 sentences)
- Motivation - Why are you adventuring?

Your character is ready to play.

Training & Advancement

In the 24-System, characters do not gain levels or experience points. They grow through **declared intent, lived experience, and consequence**.

Advancement is tied to **story arcs**, downtime, and meaningful survival, not to combat counts or numerical accumulation.

Story Arcs

A **story arc** is a complete narrative unit, such as:

- clearing or escaping a major location,
- surviving a dangerous journey,
- resolving a faction conflict,
- completing a long-term objective,
- or a period of focused downtime and training.

Advancement checks occur **only at the end of a story arc**.

Training Declaration

At the start of a story arc, each character may declare **one** of the following:

- **Train a Trait**
  Declare one trait you are actively working toward.

OR

- **Improve a Skill**
  Declare one skill you are focusing on improving.

This declaration represents intent and direction. It has **no immediate mechanical effect**.

Skill Advancement

If a character completes a story arc without abandoning their training, they may increase the declared skill by **one tier**, subject to the **Skill Pyramid rule**.

Skill Pyramid Rule A character may only advance a skill if they have **at least one other skill at the tier below it**.

Example:

- To raise a skill to Tier 3, the character must already have at least one other skill at Tier 2.

This prevents extreme specialization and represents the need for supporting competence.

A character may only gain **one skill increase per story arc**.

Trait Acquisition

Traits are **earned**, not automatically granted.

If a character completes a story arc while actively training a trait, and the training was meaningfully represented in play, they gain that trait.

Training may include:

- in-world instruction or mentorship,
- repeated exposure to relevant danger,
- sustained behavior aligned with the trait,
- or narrative consequences that reinforce it.

The Guide should not require performance or acting; **intent and engagement are sufficient**.

A character may only gain **one new trait per story arc**.

Interrupted or Failed Training

Training may be interrupted or invalidated if:

- the character abandons the declared goal,
- circumstances make the training impossible,
- or a major injury or complication fundamentally changes the outcome.

When this happens, the Guide may:

- allow the player to re-declare training,
- delay advancement until the next arc,
- or award a **different trait** that reflects what actually occurred.

Failure is still progression.

Guide Guidance

When a player declares training, the Guide should:

- look for **at least one moment per session** where that training is tested, reinforced, or complicated,
- incorporate the declaration into obstacles, consequences, or opportunities,
- and let the world respond honestly to the character's intent.

Training is not a promise of success. It is a declaration of who the character is trying to become.

Design Note

Advancement in the 24-System is not about becoming safer or stronger. It is about becoming **more defined**.

Characters grow through commitment, scars, reputation, and survival.

Skills

Skills define **what kinds of actions a character can attempt**, not passive bonuses. Each skill grants explicit actions players may declare.

Use this format for every action:

- `RLHF:` Required body anchors (`R`, `L`, `H`, `F`).
- `Check:` Which skill roll is used.
- `DC:` Typical target numbers for non-contested actions.
- `On Success:` What the action does.

If an action is contested, the initiator rolls against a DC equal to the defender's average result for the relevant defensive skill/tier (meet or beat). Apply wound penalties from `wounds.md` using the action's required anchors.

Reaction Commitment Rule

By default, reactions do **not** require `H`.

- A reaction can only use anchors the character did **not** spend on their own turn.
- If a reaction needs `L`, `R`, or `F`, that anchor must be uncommitted from the character's last declared action.
- A reaction only requires `H` if a specific rule explicitly says it does.
- Dodge exception: spending `F` on normal movement/reposition does not consume Dodge.
- High-commitment footwork (`Sprint`/`Leap`) does consume Dodge unless a trait explicitly allows otherwise.

Skill Duration

Use these duration tags to pace actions without stopwatch tracking:

- `Instant`: resolves in the current action/beat.
- `Short`: about one focused action (can stretch under pressure).
- `Extended`: multiple actions/beats; usually interrupted by danger.
- `Scene`: remains relevant for the current scene unless fiction breaks it.
- `Sustained`: lasts while actively maintained by the user.

Duration can shift by fiction:

- Partial Critical may reduce one duration step for time-sensitive actions.
- Legendary Success can reduce two steps when numerically sensible.

Skill Rank Dice

Use the skill's rank when rolling that skill:

Rank	Roll	Average Result	Contested DC (Rounded Up)
0	`2d12`	`8.49`	`9`
1	`d10 + d12 + 2`	`9.88`	`10`
2	`2d10 + 4`	`11.15`	`12`
3	`d8 + d10 + 6`	`12.55`	`13`
4	`2d8 + 8`	`13.81`	`14`
5	`d6 + d8 + 10`	`15.23`	`16`
6	`2d6 + 12`	`16.47`	`17`

Roll all dice, take the highest die, then add the flat bonus. Leverage and Pressure from `core.md` still apply.

Contested Checks (Explicit Rule)

For any action marked contested:

- Identify the defender's relevant skill tier.
- Use that tier's **Average Result** from the table, rounded up, as the DC.
- Initiator rolls normally and must meet or beat that DC.

Example:

- Attacker Shove at Rank 2 rolls `2d10 + 4`.
- Defender has Rank 3 Athletics (`d8 + d10 + 6`), average `12.55`.
- Shove DC is `13` (round up), so attacker needs `13+`.

Difficulty Benchmarks

DC	Difficulty
6	Trivial
8	Easy
10	Average
12	Moderate
14	Hard
16	Very Hard
18+	Nearly Impossible

Guideline for declared actions:

- If task is routine and low risk, no roll.
- If task has danger, time pressure, or meaningful consequence, roll.

Rule of Cool DC Offset

To keep play fast and cinematic, apply a `-2 DC` offset to all **non-contested** DCs in this document.

- Minimum adjusted DC is `6`.
- Contested checks do **not** use this offset; they still use defender average rounded up.

Legendary Conversion Rule

`Legendary Success:` gain all listed Partial Critical effects and double all numeric values in those effects. The Guide may add one cinematic rider when fiction strongly supports it.

Blindness Reference

Blindness and other scene conditions are defined in `status-effects.md`.

Athletics

Theme: Whole-body exertion, balance, force, terrain.

Core Actions

- **Sprint**
  `RLHF: F`
  `Check: Athletics`
  `Duration: Instant DC: 10` rough terrain, `12` crowded or unstable ground, `14+` hazards while sprinting.
  `On Success:` Spend 1 stamina, gain `+2 MR` this round. Rank 2: first sprint each scene is free. Rank 4: first two are free. Rank 6: first three are free. `Partial Critical (choose one):` gain +2 MR this round; or ignore difficult terrain this move; or refund stamina cost. `On Miss`: Spend 1 stamina, but move normally.

- **Leap**
  `RLHF: FH`
  `Check: Athletics`
  `Duration: Instant DC by distance:`
  Horizontal: `8`=5 ft, `10`=8 ft, `12`=10 ft, `14`=12 ft, `16`=15 ft, `18`=20 ft, `20`=25 ft.
  Vertical: `8`=1.5 ft, `10`=2 ft, `12`=3 ft, `14`=4 ft, `16`=6 ft, `18`=8 ft, `20`=10 ft.
  `On Success:` Clear the gap/height.
  `Partial Critical (choose one):` land in ideal footing; or add +5 ft horizontal or +1 ft vertical; or carry one adjacent ally/item without penalty. `On Miss:` Land short, hang at edge, or fall per terrain danger.

- **Climb**
  `RLHF: LRFH`
  `Check: Athletics`
  `Duration: Short DC: 8` ladder/rope, `12` rough wall, `16` slick wall, `18+` overhang/no holds.
  `On Success:` Move up to half MR vertically (or full MR with fixed gear).
  `Partial Critical (choose one):` climb at full MR this action; or leave

a stable route granting one advantage step to next climber; or ignore one hazard on the route.

- **Swim**
  `RLHF: LRFH`
  `Check: Athletics`
  `Duration: Short DC: 10` calm water, `12` current, `14` storm/drain pull, `16+` armor or injury in strong current.
  `On Success:` Move half MR in water (full MR if unarmored and calm). `Partial Critical (choose one):` move full MR in water this action; or avoid breath loss/panic cost this round; or tow one creature one range step.

Contested / Tactical Actions

- **Shove / Bullrush**
  `RLHF: LHF`
  `Check: Athletics (contested vs Athletics or Melee)`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Push target 5 ft or break their engagement. Beat by 4+: push 10 ft or knock prone. `Partial Critical (choose one):` push +5 extra ft; or choose push, prone, and off-guard (instead of one); or you remain in strong stance and gain one advantage step on next grapple/shove.

- **Tumble**
  `RLHF: FH`
  `Check: Athletics (contested vs opponent Melee)`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Move through threatened space without giving free melee response. `Partial Critical (choose one):` move an additional 5 ft; or deny target reaction until end of round; or end in cover or flanking position.

- **Break Free**
  `RLHF: L(R)F`
  `Check: Athletics (contested vs grappler Athletics/Melee)`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` End one grapple/restraint lock on self. `Partial Critical (choose one):` break one additional lock; or reposition 5 ft immediately; or impose +2 DC on grappler next maintain attempt. `Note: H` is not required for Break Free.

Environmental Actions

- **Navigate Dangerous Terrain**
  `RLHF: FH`
  `Check: Athletics`
  `Duration: Short DC: 10` rubble, `12` ice/mud, `14` collapsing footing, `16+` moving hazard.
  `On Success:` Cross without falling or losing action tempo. `Partial`

`Critical (choose one):` cross at full speed; or grant one ally one advantage step to follow same path; or avoid triggering latent terrain hazard.

Melee

Theme: Close-range violence, weapon control, physical dominance.

Core Actions

- **Strike**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Option`: Add R, to strike with two-handed weapon, or a weapon with the versatile quality. `Check: Melee (vs target defense DC)`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Deal normal weapon wound(s). `Partial Critical (choose one):` gain +1 wound or force off-Guard; or shift 5 ft after hit; or deny one reaction from target this round.

- **Full Martial Strike**
  `RLHF: L(R)HF`
  `Option`: Add R, to strike with two-handed weapon, or a weapon with the versatile quality. `Check: Melee` vs target defense DC plus one step advantage. `Duration: Instant On Success:` Deal normal weapon wound(s). `Partial Critical (choose one):` add +1 wounds instead of baseline bonus; or force prone/off-Guard together; or immediately pressure a second adjacent target.

Defensive / Reactive Actions

- **Parry**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Melee (contested vs incoming melee roll)`
  `Duration: Instant (Reaction) On Success:` Negate hit. Beat by 4+: negate and gain +1 Leverage on next melee action. `Partial Critical (choose one):` immediately riposte at +2 DC; or disarm or bind on the deflection; or retain Guard against one additional approach.

- **Bind Weapon**
  `RLHF: LRHF`
  `Check: Melee (contested)`
  `Duration: Short On Success:` Target cannot use bound weapon for its next action unless it wins a Break Free/Disengage contest. `Partial Critical (choose one):` target needs two successes to free weapon; or you may reposition target 5 ft while maintaining bind; or next allied melee action gains one advantage step vs bound target.

Control Actions

- **Disarm**
  `RLHF: LHF`
  `Check: Melee (contested)`
  `Duration: Instant  DC/Modifier: +2 DC if target uses two hands.`
  `On Success:` Target drops or loses ready access to weapon. `Partial Critical (choose one):` weapon lands in a space you choose within 10 ft; or target also becomes off-Guard; or you may immediately seize or kick away the weapon.

- **Grapple**
  `RLHF: L or R (minimum one free limb)`
  `Check: Melee or Athletics (contested)`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Establish one limb lock on target and enter Grappling state. `Partial Critical (choose one):` apply one additional lock if you have a free limb; or inflict disoriented on target until end of next turn; or establish lock and reposition target 5 ft.

- **Maintain Grapple**
  `RLHF: L or R (locked limb must remain committed)`
  `Check: Melee or Athletics (contested each round control is challenged)`
  `Duration: Sustained On Success:` Existing lock(s) remain in place with an option to commit additional limbs. `Partial Critical (choose one):` add one new lock without separate grapple roll; or deal 1 wound from crushing control; or deny target all non-break reactions this round.

- **Throw**
  `RLHF: L or R (requires at least one active lock)`
  `Check: Athletics or Melee (contested)`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Move target 5-10 ft and knock prone. Into hazard adds situational consequence. `Partial Critical (choose one):` increase throw distance by 5 ft; or target takes +1 wound from impact; or you may remain standing and ready without losing stance.

Grapple Framework

- One committed limb restrains one target anchor (`L`, `R`, `F`, or `H`).
- Additional successful Grapple actions add additional locks by committing additional limbs.
- If a target has one or more locks on them, their speed is `0`.
- A restrained anchor cannot be used for other actions; it can only be used to attempt `Break Free`.
- You cannot initiate a grapple with `H`, but `H` can be restrained.
- If you have no active lock on the target, attacks or grapple attempts without `H` are blind and use the Blind status rules from `status-effects.md`.

- Once you have at least one active lock on that target, you are not blind against them: additional grapples and attacks do not require `H` and take no blind penalty.
- If 3 of the target's limbs/anchors are restrained, the target is fully restrained; their remaining unrestrained limb/anchor is treated as unusable until they remove a lock.

Ranged

Theme: Precision, timing, and distance control.

Core Actions

- **Aim**
  `RLHF: LH`
  `Check: Ranged`
  `Duration: Short DC: 10` under light pressure, `12+` if target partially obscured.
  `On Success:` Gain +1 Leverage die on next `Fire/Called Shot` before end of next turn. `Partial Critical (choose one):` also reduce one cover penalty tier; or carry aim benefit through your next turn if not fired; or gain one extra advantage step on next Fire/Called Shot.

- **Fire**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Ranged (vs target defense DC)`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Deal weapon wound(s). `Partial Critical (choose one):` conserve ammo; or force target off-Guard; or gain immediate 5 ft reposition without penalty.

- **Rapid Fire**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Ranged at +2 DC`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Two hits at -1 wound each (minimum 0), or split fire across two close targets. `Partial Critical (choose one):` both hits deal full weapon wounds; or suppress both targets you engaged; or do not suffer the rapid-fire accuracy increase next time this scene.

Tactical Actions

- **Suppress**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Ranged`
  `Duration: Short DC: 12` doorway/choke, `14` open lane, `16+` wide lane.
  `On Success:` Enemies crossing lane take +2 DC on move/advance or risk

immediate attack. `Partial Critical (choose one):` cover a second adjacent lane; or duration extends one additional round; or targets crossing also lose one reaction.

- **Called Shot**
  `RLHF: LH`
  `Check: Ranged`
  `Duration: Instant DC Modifier:` Core +0, Arms/Legs +2, Head +2 (per `combat.md`).
  `On Success:` Apply wound to called location. `Partial Critical (choose one):` ignore called-shot modifier; or apply a status effect tied to hit location; or also force target to drop/lose one held item.

- **Cover Fire**
  `RLHF: LH`
  `Check: Ranged`
  `Duration: Short DC: 12`
  `On Success:` One ally moving this round ignores one enemy reaction from your covered direction. `Partial Critical (choose one):` affect one additional ally movement; or also pin target attention (+2 DC to their next offensive action); or conserve ammo on this covering action.

Thievery

Theme: Stealth, fine motor control, covert manipulation.

Stealth Procedure (Scene Rule)

- One successful stealth check can cover an entire scene.
- No additional stealth roll is needed unless the character takes an overt action or the fiction changes sharply.
- Overt actions include loud violence, open sprinting in view, breaking obvious cover, or direct interaction with a guarded target.
- When a new stealth check is required, resolve it immediately at the point of exposure risk.

NPCs track awareness as:

- `Relaxed -> Alert -> Suspicious -> Aware`

On a failed stealth check:

- Increase affected NPCs by one awareness step.
- At `Aware`, they can actively engage, call out, and normal stealth is uncontestable.

Breaking `Aware` requires misdirection, not simple concealment:

- Hiding behind nearby cover alone is insufficient if they already know your location.
- You must create a believable false lead (noise, decoy movement, staged trail, etc.), then re-enter stealth.
- Example: opening a manhole to imply escape there, then hiding under a tarp can justify a new stealth check.

Core Actions

- **Sneak**
  `RLHF: FH`
  `Check: Thievery (opposed by observer Perception/Lore as appropriate)`
  `Duration: Scene On Success:` Move quietly without drawing attention. `Partial Critical (choose one):` move an extra short distance while hidden; or leave no trace for immediate trackers; or create a brief opening for one ally to follow unseen.

- **Hide**
  `RLHF: FH`
  `Check: Thievery`
  `Duration: Scene DC: 10` cluttered area, `12` sparse cover, `14+` brief concealment windows.
  `On Success:` Break line of sight and remain concealed until fiction changes. `Partial Critical (choose one):` remain hidden despite brief exposure; or gain one advantage step on first action from hiding; or create a decoy sign that misdirects searchers.

- **Pick Lock**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Thievery`
  `Duration: Short (Extended on hard locks) DC: 10` simple, `12` common, `14` quality lock, `16+` reinforced/security design.
  `On Success:` Open lock quietly. `Partial Critical (choose one):` open lock silently and quickly; or do not leave tamper evidence; or keep mechanism intact for clean relock.

- **Disable Device**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Thievery`
  `Duration: Short (Extended on complex traps) DC: 12` known trap, `14` unfamiliar mechanism, `16+` complex/booby-trapped device.
  `On Success:` Device is safely disarmed. `Partial Critical (choose one):` disarm and learn reset method; or convert trap into one-use advantage for your side; or disable adjacent linked trigger as well.

Combat-Relevant Actions

- **Steal**
  `RLHF: LHF`
  `Check: Thievery (contested vs target Awareness/Lore)`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Remove one small carried item. `Partial Critical (choose one):` take one additional small item; or target does not realize loss until scene changes; or plant minor false clue while lifting item.

- **Sabotage**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Thievery`
  `Duration: Short (Extended on reinforced targets) DC: 10` simple gear, `12` weapon, `14` armor fitting, `16+` reinforced mechanism.
  `On Success:` Target object gains a failure condition on next use. `Partial Critical (choose one):` failure effect is severe (breaks on first use); or sabotage remains hidden until triggered; or affect one adjacent connected component.

- **Plant Object**
  `RLHF: LHF`
  `Check: Thievery`
  `Duration: Short DC: 10` distracted target, `12` alert target, `14+` active search conditions.
  `On Success:` Object remains unnoticed until searched or triggered. `Partial Critical (choose one):` placement is undetectable without focused search; or object can be triggered remotely/simple condition; or also create false evidence trail.

Reaction Actions

- **Slip Away**
  `RLHF: FH`
  `Check: Thievery (contested vs nearest threat Awareness)`
  `Duration: Instant (Reaction) On Success:` Exit engagement without immediate pursuit response. `Partial Critical (choose one):` also break line of sight immediately; or pursuer chooses wrong direction; or you may move full speed while disengaging.

- **Feign Innocence**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Thievery or Social`
  `Duration: Short DC: 10` casual suspicion, `14` active accusation, `16+` direct witness.
  `On Success:` Delay or redirect suspicion. `Partial Critical (choose one):` shift suspicion to alternate plausible target; or buy one full round before renewed scrutiny; or observers lower alertness one tier.

Lore

Theme: Knowledge, recognition, inference.

Core Actions

- **Recall Knowledge**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Lore`
  `Duration: Instant DC: 8` common fact, `12` specialized, `16` obscure, `20+` forbidden/esoteric.
  `On Success:` Learn a correct useful fact. `Partial Critical (choose one):` gain one extra actionable fact; or fact includes immediate tactical application; or reduce next related check DC by 2.

- **Analyze Threat**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Lore`
  `Duration: Short DC: 12`
  `On Success:` Learn one practical weakness, behavior trigger, or likely tactic. `Partial Critical (choose one):` identify both weakness and behavior trigger; or grant one ally one advantage step vs this threat; or predict target next likely action.

- **Interpret Signs**
  `RLHF: FH`
  `Check: Lore`
  `Duration: Short DC: 10` clear clues, `12` mixed traces, `14+` degraded scene.
  `On Success:` Establish what happened and direction/timing. `Partial Critical (choose one):` determine exact timing and direction; or spot hidden secondary clue; or grant group one advantage step on next tracking/search action.

Preparatory Actions

- **Formulate Plan**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Lore`
  `Duration: Short DC: 12`
  `On Success:` Grant one ally +1 Leverage die on first related action. `Partial Critical (choose one):` grant two allies one advantage step each; or also reduce one foreseeable complication; or plan remains valid for one extra scene beat.

- **Predict Outcome**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Lore`
  `Duration: Instant DC: 14`
  `On Success:` Guide states one likely consequence before commitment. `Partial Critical (choose one):` receive best and worst likely branch; or gain one advantage step if acting on prediction immediately; or identify hidden cost before commitment.

Reactive Actions

- **Recognize Pattern**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Lore`
  `Duration: Instant (Reaction) DC: 12` repeating behavior, `14` subtle setup, `16+` highly concealed pattern.
  `On Success:` Act before trap/ambush fully resolves. `Partial Critical (choose one):` interrupt the pattern before it triggers; or identify controller/source behind pattern; or grant party one free reposition before resolution.

Science

Theme: Medicine, engineering, chemistry, physics.

Core Actions

- **Diagnose**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Science`
  `Duration: Short DC: 10` obvious injury/fault, `12` mixed symptoms, `14+` rare or hidden cause.
  `On Success:` Identify root cause and best immediate intervention. `Partial Critical (choose one):` determine root cause and best treatment path; or identify one hidden complication early; or grant one advantage step to next treatment/check.

- **Treat Wound**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Science`
  `Duration: Short (Extended for severe trauma) DC: 10` basic first aid, `12` stabilize severe bleed, `14+` field surgery conditions.
  `On Success:` Stabilize target and remove one immediate complication from the wound state. `Partial Critical (choose one):` remove one

additional immediate complication; or restore functional use of a recently impaired anchor for this scene; or treatment holds longer under pressure.

- **Engineer Bypass**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Science`
  `Duration: Short (Extended on hardened systems)` `DC: 12` simple mechanism, `14` secured system, `16+` hardened system.
  `On Success:` Temporarily bypass lockout/power/control issue. `Partial Critical (choose one):` bypass lasts for full scene; or leave no forensic sign of bypass; or create safe fallback route if bypass collapses.

- **Analyze Substance**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Science`
  `Duration: Short` `DC: 10` common substance, `14` mixed compounds, `18+` exotic/occult contamination.
  `On Success:` Learn key properties, hazard, and safe handling. `Partial Critical (choose one):` identify exact composition and immediate antidote/neutralizer route; or detect trace contamination source; or grant one advantage step on next handling/use.

- **Improvise Tool**
  `RLHF: L(R)H`
  `Check: Science`
  `Duration: Short` `DC: 12` simple, `14` precise, `16+` high-pressure improvised build.
  `On Success:` Create temporary tool usable for a single action. `Partial Critical (choose one):` tool functions for full scene instead of one use; or tool grants one extra advantage step on first use; or build time is halved.

Social

Theme: Influence, pressure, and presence.

Core Actions

- **Persuade**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Social (contested for resistant targets)`
  `Duration: Short` `DC: 10` receptive, `12` uncertain, `14` resistant, `16+` hostile.
  `On Success:` Target accepts a reasonable request or concession. `Partial Critical (choose one):` target also offers useful concession; or effect lasts one additional scene beat; or one bystander becomes favorable too.

- **Deceive**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Social (contested vs target Lore/Social)`
  `Duration: Short On Success:` Target believes false claim until contradictory evidence appears. `Partial Critical (choose one):` lie survives immediate verification attempt; or target repeats lie to others as truth; or gain one advantage step on follow-up social action.

- **Intimidate**
  `RLHF: HF`
  `Check: Social`
  `Duration: Instant DC: 10` weaker foe, `14` equal foe, `16+` disciplined foe.
  `On Success:` Target hesitates, yields space, or accepts short-term compliance. `Partial Critical (choose one):` target withdraws or yields space immediately; or target loses next reaction; or nearby weaker witness also hesitates.

- **Command**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Social`
  `Duration: Instant DC: 10` ally subordinate, `12` ally peer under stress, `14+` contested authority.
  `On Success:` One ally may immediately adjust position or clear a fear hesitation. `Partial Critical (choose one):` ally acts immediately and gains one advantage step; or order also steadies fear by 1; or two allies can take minor reposition instead of one.

Tactical / Combat-Adjacent Actions

- **Distract**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Social`
  `Duration: Instant DC: 12`
  `On Success:` Target loses one reaction or suffers +2 DC on next action. `Partial Critical (choose one):` target loses both reaction and focus bonus; or create opening granting one ally one advantage step; or target misreads your next move.

- **Provoke**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Social (contested)`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Target commits to an aggressive or suboptimal action chosen by Guide within fiction. `Partial Critical (choose one):` target commits to a predictable line; or target suffers +2 DC on defense until end of turn; or nearby enemies hesitate before assisting.

- **Rally**

`RLHF: H`
`Check: Social`
`Duration: Short DC: 12` in cover/safety, `14` under active threat, `16+` panic conditions.
`On Success:` One ally reduces fear by 1 step or gains +1 Leverage on next defense. `Partial Critical (choose one):` affect one additional ally; or also clear one minor complication tied to panic/fatigue; or all rallied allies gain one advantage step on next defense.

Consequence-Driven Actions

- **Posture**
  `RLHF: HF`
  `Check: Social`
  `Duration: Scene DC: 12`
  `On Success:` Establish local dominance; first opposed social check this scene gains +1 Leverage. `Partial Critical (choose one):` establish dominance over a wider audience; or first two opposed social checks this scene gain one advantage step; or opponent must answer your framing or cede ground.
- **Undermine**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Social`
  `Duration: Short DC: 12` fragile cohesion, `14` disciplined group, `16+` fanatic loyalty.
  `On Success:` Reduce enemy morale/cohesion and impose +2 DC on their next coordinated action. `Partial Critical (choose one):` enemy coordination penalty lasts one extra round; or fracture one key relationship in opposing group; or their next leader command carries +2 DC.

Magic

Theme: Controlled violation of natural rules. Availability is setting-dependent.

Core Actions

- **Cast**
  `RLHF: LH`
  `Check: Magic`
  `Duration: Instant DC:` Set by spell profile in `spells.md`.
  `On Success:` Spell manifests as intended. `Partial Critical (choose one):` add one minor rider effect consistent with spell type; or reduce immediate backlash by one step; or gain one advantage step on next Sustain/Focus.

- **Sustain**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Magic`
  `Duration: Sustained DC: 10` stable effect, `12` contested zone, `14+` high-pressure scene.
  `On Success:` Ongoing effect continues without escalation. `Partial Critical (choose one):` extend duration by one tier; or free one anchor normally tied up by sustain strain; or stabilize effect against one disruption source.

- **Focus**
  `RLHF: H`
  `Check: Magic`
  `Duration: Instant DC: 12`
  `On Success:` Gain +1 Leverage die on next magic action or reduce backlash severity by one step. `Partial Critical (choose one):` gain two advantage steps on next magic action; or also cancel one pending backlash complication; or retain Guard-equivalent awareness against one approach.

Defensive / Reactive Actions

- **Counter**
  `RLHF: LH`
  `Check: Magic (contested vs caster)`
  `Duration: Instant (Reaction) On Success:` Interrupt incoming magical effect. `Partial Critical (choose one):` counter and reflect minor portion of effect; or counter without losing your next planned action; or impose +2 DC on enemy next cast.

- **Dispel**
  `RLHF: LH`
  `Check: Magic`
  `Duration: Instant DC: 12` minor effect, `14` sustained effect, `16+` entrenched ritual effect.
  `On Success:` End or suppress target effect. `Partial Critical (choose one):` dispel and learn signature/source; or suppress nearby related effect for one round; or convert residual energy to one advantage step for ally.

- **Ward**
  `RLHF: LH`
  `Check: Magic`
  `Duration: Scene DC: 12` personal ward, `14` area ward, `16+` layered ward.
  `On Success:` Protected target gains +2 DC versus one defined threat category. `Partial Critical (choose one):` ward covers one extra adjacent target/zone; or ward gains one additional trigger/use; or ward also imposes minor backlash on first attacker.

Risk Actions

- **Overchannel**
  `RLHF: LH`
  `Check: Magic at +2 DC`
  `Duration: Instant On Success:` Increase one spell parameter (range, duration, or potency) by one tier.
  `Partial Critical (choose one):` gain two spell parameter tiers instead of one; or avoid immediate backlash step increase; or retain one free follow-up Focus this round. `On Miss:` Spell still manifests in type, but backlash escalates one step.

- **Ritualize**
  `RLHF: LRFH`
  `Check: Magic`
  `Duration: Extended DC: 14` prepared circle/text, `16` partial prep, `18+` rushed/hostile conditions.
  `On Success:` Complete long-form effect with reduced immediate backlash.
  `Partial Critical (choose one):` ritual time reduced by one tier; or effect gains strong stability and duration; or participants gain one advantage step on immediate aftermath actions.

Design Notes

- Skills define available actions, not static passive bonuses.
- RLHF anchor commitment keeps consequences grounded in body state.
- Rank changes both dice quality and flat bonus, making skill growth reliable under pressure.
- For edge cases, use the nearest action here as baseline, then tune DC by fiction.

Narrative Based Perception

In this game, there's no Perception stat or automatic search check. Instead, players uncover secrets, traps, and hidden features through their actions and attention to the story.

When you describe your character's investigations—asking questions, examining the environment, or testing suspicions—the Guide responds with clues based on what your character actually does, what they know, and which skills they use. Sharp observations and clever ideas matter more than a lucky roll.

Pay attention to details in the Guide's descriptions. Subtle sights, sounds, smells, or textures may hint at secrets or dangers waiting to be discovered.

Tips for Narrative Discovery (Players)

- **Ask specific questions:**
  "Does the air feel different near this wall?"
  "Are there scratches by the lock?"
- **Describe your actions:**
  Don't just say "I search the room." Try:
  "I tap the flagstones with my staff and run my hand along the wall."
- **Work together:**
  Share hunches and combine different skills (Lore, Thievery, Magic) for better results.
- **Stay curious:**
  Sometimes the smallest detail is the key to finding what others miss.

Tips for Narrative Discovery (Guide)

- **Always include a clue:**
  Every secret, trap, or hidden feature should have at least one subtle hint. This might be a scent, draft, odd sound, or visual irregularity.
- **Make clues fit the world:**
  A hidden library might smell of old paper.
  A trapped hallway might have a slightly raised flagstone.
- **Reward curiosity, not just skills:**
  Clever questions and creative interaction should yield useful information, even without the "right" skill.
- **Use multiple senses:**
  Describe not only what is seen, but also what is heard, smelled, or felt.
- **Layer clues:**
  Obvious clues reward careful play; deeper clues reward expertise (Lore, Thievery, Magic).
- **Let players connect the dots:**
  Present clues honestly and allow players to draw conclusions. Do not force solutions.
- **Keep danger fair:**
  Never spring traps or secrets without foreshadowing. "Gotchas" break trust; hints build tension.
- **Encourage teamwork:**
  Secrets are easier to uncover when players share information and combine perspectives.

Secret Doors & Panels

Secret doors and panels are not found through rolls. They are discovered through observation, interaction, and narrative clues. The Guide should always foreshadow their presence through environmental details before a player can uncover or activate them.

Secret Door / Panel Hints

Environmental signs that a secret is present

Unusual Smells

- Musty old books (hidden library or archive)
- Scent of earth or fresh air (tunnel or outside passage)
- Incense, alchemical residue, or faint metallic tang

Temperature Changes

- Slight draft or chill near a wall
- Noticeably warmer or cooler patch of air

Odd Sounds

- Muffled voices or noises through a wall
- Faint echo or muted footsteps at one spot
- Hollow sound when tapping wall or floor

Visual Clues

- Misaligned or scratched sconce, bracket, or torch
- Seams or subtle discoloration in stonework or paneling
- Worn or scuffed flagstones or floorboards
- Torches burning lower or unusual soot marks, suggesting frequent use

Movement & Vibrations

- Slight tremor as a door is operated elsewhere
- Books, objects, or furnishings that seem recently disturbed

Light & Shadow

- Shadows behaving oddly, outlines too sharp, or movement that doesn't match the light source
- A faint outline of a door or panel visible only at certain angles or lighting

Dust & Usage

- Unusually dust-free patches in an otherwise neglected area
- Footprints that end abruptly at a wall or dead end

Secret Door / Panel Triggers

How the secret is opened

Mechanical Triggers

- Twisting, pulling, or pushing a specific torch, sconce, or candlestick
- Pressing a particular brick, stone, or floor tile
- Pulling a specific book, often unmarked or oddly worn

Hidden Latches & Levers

- Nearly invisible latch disguised as part of the décor
- Lever concealed behind a painting, tapestry, or statue
- Floor tile that depresses under weight or pressure

Combination Actions

- Pulling two sconces at the same time
- Turning objects in a specific sequence
- Multi-step mechanisms that require experimentation

Magical Triggers

- Speaking a password or phrase
- Casting a specific spell (e.g., *Knock*, *Light*)
- Tracing a rune or symbol with a finger, wand, or tool

Environmental Triggers

- Only opens at a specific time (midnight, full moon, dawn)
- Requires placing a specific item into a recess
- Activated by breath, heat, cold, or moisture

Hidden in Plain Sight

- Decorative panels that swing open when pressed
- Bookshelves mounted on concealed hinges or wheels
- Doors concealed behind mirrors, statues, or furniture

Spellcasting Axioms

- **Magic always works.**
- A spell always produces its *type* of effect:
  - Wards always ward.
  - Summons always summon.
  - Distortions always distort.
- Spell rolls determine **how** the effect manifests, not **whether** it manifests.
- Bad outcomes cause **backlash, escalation, or unwanted consequences**, never null effects.
- Magic never grants ownership or control, only influence.
- Most spells require **Head** and interfere with mundane defense while active.
- Spells cost **stamina** and may cause wounds or attention on poor results.

Elder Sign

Type: Control / Ward
Action: Head
Cost: 1 stamina
Targets: Supernatural creatures interacting with the warded area
Duration: Until start of your next turn (may sustain for 1 stamina)

You inscribe or assert a symbol that reality recognizes as rejection.

Always:

- The area is **warded against the supernatural**.

Roll Magic once. Apply the result:

- **Failure:**
  - The ward is weak.
  - Supernatural creatures may advance, but suffer **hesitation or distortion**.
- **Critical Failure:**
  - As Failure.
  - You suffer **1 arm wound** (your choice).
- **Success:**
  - The ward holds.
  - Supernatural creatures **cannot advance** into the warded area.
- **Partial Critical:**
  - As Success.
  - Creatures that attempt to advance suffer **1 core wound**.

- **Legendary:**
  - As Success.
  - Creatures that attempt to advance suffer **2 core wounds** and are **thrown from the area**.

The Colour Out of Space

Type: Intrusion / Summoning
Action: Head + one Hand
Cost: 1 stamina
Target: One creature or point in space

You expose the target to something that should not exist.

Always:

- An otherworldly intrusion occurs.
- A hostile aberrant growth **will manifest**.

Roll Magic once. Apply the result:

- **Failure:**
  - Target suffers **1 stamina damage**.
  - A **Lesser Colour Growth** manifests at end of round.
- **Critical Failure:**
  - As Failure.
  - Growth manifests **immediately**.
  - You suffer **1 stamina backlash**.
- **Success:**
  - Target suffers **1 wound (ignores armor)**.
  - Growth manifests **immediately**, hostile to all.
- **Partial Critical:**
  - As Success.
  - Growth is **larger or faster** and acts before the target.
- **Legendary:**
  - As Success.
  - Growth expands into adjacent space, warping the area and escalating the threat.

The Call

Type: Compulsion / Lure
Action: Head
Cost: 1 stamina
Target: One creature or a point in space within sight

You broadcast an invitation that should never be heard.
Something answers. The question is **what** and **how**.

Always:

- A compulsion manifests.
- Affected creatures feel an undeniable pull toward the call.

Roll Magic once. Apply the result:

- **Critical Failure:**
  - The call is uncontrolled.
  - The nearest hostile creature is drawn toward **you** instead.
  - You suffer **1 stamina backlash** or become **disoriented**.
- **Failure:**
  - The call emanates from the wrong place.
  - The creature is drawn toward a **nearby unintended location**.
- **Success:**
  - The creature is compelled to move toward the chosen location on its next turn.
  - It must advance if able, even if doing so is dangerous.
- **Partial Critical:**
  - As Success.
  - The creature suffers **hesitation** and cannot take reactions while moving.
- **Legendary:**
  - As Success.
  - The creature is **urgently drawn**, advancing immediately if possible.
  - You may affect **one additional nearby creature**.

Pseudo-Apotheosis

Type: Permanent Transformation / Adaptation
Action: Head + Body
Cost: 1 stamina
Target: Self

You force your body into a higher functional state it was never meant to sustain.

Always:

- One physical adaptation becomes **permanent**.
- Each adaptation permanently removes or degrades a human capability.

Choose **one adaptation** when casting.

Roll Magic once. Apply the result:

- **Critical Failure:**
  - The adaptation manifests violently.
  - You gain the adaptation and suffer **1 wound** or a severe visible deformity.
- **Failure:**
  - The adaptation works, but with pronounced drawbacks.
  - Increase the listed downside.
- **Success:**
  - The adaptation works as described.
- **Partial Critical:**
  - The adaptation integrates cleanly.
  - Reduce the listed downside slightly.
- **Legendary:**
  - The adaptation is near-perfect.
  - The downside remains, but is less intrusive or easier to manage.

The Unveiling

Type: Revelation / Analysis
Action: Head
Cost: 1 stamina
Target: One supernatural creature, object, or phenomenon within sight

You force understanding where understanding was never meant to exist.

Always:

- You learn something **true and useful** about the target.
- The knowledge is real, immediate, and unsettling.

Roll Magic once. Apply the result:

- **Critical Failure:**
  - The truth is overwhelming.

  - You gain critical insight, but suffer **mental fracture**.
  - You cannot clearly communicate the information this round and suffer a severe penalty on mental actions.

- **Failure:**
  - The truth arrives distorted or unfiltered.
  - You learn something important, but must choose **one detail** to convey to the party.
  - You suffer **disorientation or stress**.

- **Success:**
  - You learn actionable information about the target.
  - You may clearly communicate it to the party.

- **Partial Critical:**
  - As Success.
  - Gain an additional useful detail or warning.

- **Legendary:**
  - The truth aligns cleanly.
  - You gain deep insight and may ask one focused follow-up question about the target.

24-System Player Playtest Packet

The 24-System is a flexible, consequence-forward RPG engine designed to create tension without sudden character collapse. Actions have lasting effects, resources erode over time, and pushing your luck carries risk, but characters remain playable even when things go wrong. The goal is sustained pressure and meaningful choice, not instant death or runaway death spirals.

Survival, Pressure, and the Cost of Commitment

Playtest Document

This is not a complete rulebook.
Momentum and clarity take priority over precision.
The GM may rule quickly and move play forward.

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1. What Kind of Game This Is

The **24-System** is a **tactical survival-horror RPG**.

- Combat is about **space, attention, and injury**, not hit point attrition.
- You are assumed to be **competent**.

- Danger escalates through **pressure, fear, and wounds**, not random failure.
- Retreat, preparation, and avoidance are valid successes.

If you try to "solve" the system, it will hurt you.

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2. The Core Loop

On your turn, decide:

1. **What parts of your body are you committing?**
2. **What space are you controlling or giving up?**
3. **What risk are you willing to accept?**

Then:

- The GM sets a **Difficulty (DC)**.
- You roll your dice.
- The **highest die** is your result.
- **Partial Criticals matter more than totals.**

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3. The RHLF Action System ("Ralph")

Instead of action points, you commit **parts of your body**.

Anchor	Meaning	Represents
L	Primary Hand	Weapons, manipulation
R	Secondary Hand	Shields, support
H	Head	Attention, targeting, intent
F	Feet	Movement, balance, stance

Key Rule:
If a body part is **injured**, actions using it degrade.
If it is **disabled**, those actions may be unavailable.

You are limited by **what your body can still do**, not by turns.

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4. Warding & Space Control

Warding (Automatic)

If you are:

- aware of danger,

- not already engaged,
- and not committing your **Head (H)** elsewhere,

→ **you are automatically warding.**

Warding means:

- you threaten space,
- enemies must contest movement through you,
- warding is **directional and limited**.

What Breaks Warding

Any action that commits **H**, including:

- attacking,
- aiming,
- casting spells,
- tracking another threat,
- issuing complex commands.

Movement alone does **not** break warding.

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5. Attacking & Defending

Defense (Reactive)

When attacked, you may choose **one** defense per attack:

- **Dodge (F)** — evade entirely
- **Parry (L)** — redirect (weapon risk)
- **Block (R)** — absorb (shield risk)

Defense is reactive and does not need to be declared in advance.

Common Combat Actions

Action	Body Used	Notes
Attack	L	Ends warding
Focused Attack	L + H	Careful, precise
Full Martial Attack	L (R) H F	Maximum commitment
Advance	F	Close distance, may be contested
Covering Fire	L + H	Forces choices, no damage

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6. Resolution & Outcomes

You roll dice from your **skill** plus any **Leverage**.

Possible Outcomes

- **Legendary (24+)**
  Cinematic success with major effect.
- **Partial Critical (Max Die)**
  Something extra happens, even if you fail.
- **Success**
  You achieve your goal cleanly.
- **Success with Complication**
  You push forward, reroll one die, accept a setback.
- **Failure**
  You do not get what you want. The situation changes.

Failure always moves the scene forward.

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7. Leverage & Pressure

Leverage

Good positioning, planning, teamwork, or preparation.

Leverage	Bonus Die
1	d4
2	d6
3	d8
4	d10
5	d12

Roll all dice and take the **highest**.

Pressure

Danger, darkness, fear, injury, time limits.

- Pressure does **not** remove dice.
- Pressure **raises the DC**.

Skill keeps you effective.
Pressure keeps you unsafe.

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8. Wounds, Stamina, and Injury

- **Stamina** represents short-term exertion and shock.
- **Wounds** are lasting injuries.

Armor may convert wounds into stamina loss.
Once stamina goes negative, actions degrade.

Injuries:

- reduce movement,
- weaken attacks,
- disrupt strategies.

There is no "fine at 1 HP" state.

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9. Fear

Fear is tracked from **0 to 6**.

Fear does **not** remove agency.
It **biases decisions**, especially toward caution.

Fear Level	Effect
1–2	Alert, cautious
3	Hesitation when advancing
4	First hostile action loses one body anchor
5	Limited to 3 of 4 body anchors
6	Breakdown or withdrawal

Fear punishes reckless engagement, not survival.

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10. Weapons & Escalation

Weapons differ by:

- how many body parts they require,
- what happens on **Partial Criticals**.

Examples:

- **Precision** — stamina bleed, armor gaps
- **Chopping** — destroys armor
- **Crushing** — ignores mitigation

- **Reach** — controls space
- **Firearms** — escalation buttons

Bows and guns are parity weapons until crits.
Crits are terrifying.

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11. Magic (If Present)

Magic always works.
The roll determines **how dangerous it becomes**.

- Spells never fizzle.
- Failure causes backlash or escalation.
- Magic always costs **attention (H)**.

Magic is powerful, unsafe, and loud.

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12. Character Creation (Quick)

- No attributes.
- Skills determine dice.
- Choose:
  - 1 specialty skill
  - 1 strong skill
  - 2 competent skills
- Choose **2 traits**.

Your character is defined by **what you risk**.

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13. Table Expectations

- Describe intent first.
- Declare body commitment clearly.
- Don't hunt for optimal builds.
- Retreat is success.
- Ask questions.
- Trust the fiction.

If something is unclear, the GM will rule fast and move on.

Final Note to Players

This system is not here to protect you.

It is here to:

- make danger legible,
- make survival meaningful,
- and make scars matter.

If you walk away alive, it will be because you chose to.

24-System Combat Reference

Fast Table Guide (Playtest)

Core Combat Loop

1. **Warding is automatic** if you are aware and not committing H.
2. **Movement & Advances** may be contested by warding.
3. **Attacks commit H** and end warding.
4. **Defense is reactive** (choose one per attack).
5. Resolve results → apply wounds, stamina, or consequences.

RHLF Action Anchors

Anchor	Represents
L	Primary Hand (weapon use)
R	Secondary Hand (shield, support)
H	Head (attention, targeting)
F	Feet (movement, balance)

If an anchor is injured, actions using it degrade.
If disabled, those actions may be unavailable.

Range States

- **Separated** – No contact, ranged and reach dominate
- **Melee** – Weapon-length engagement
- **Grappling** – Bodies entangled, limb control

Range is categorical, not measured.

Warding & Advances

Warding

- Automatic while aware and not engaged
- Directional, limited to one approach
- Ends when you commit **H**

Advance (F)

- Move closer to an enemy
- Contested if the enemy is warding
- Failure: stop or push through (take consequence)
- Critical Failure: both

Multiple Warders

- Base difficulty set by first warder
- Each additional warder: **+2 DC**
- Only one warder resolves the consequence

Common Combat Actions

Action	Anchors	Notes
Attack	L	Ends warding
Focused Attack	L + H	Precision, control
Full Martial Attack	L (R) H F	Maximum commitment
Advance	F	Close distance
Move	F	Reposition safely
Covering Fire	L + H	Forces choices, no damage

Defense (Reactive)

Choose **one** per incoming attack:

Defense	Anchor	Effect
Dodge	F	Avoid attack
Parry	L	Redirect (weapon risk)

Defense	Anchor	Effect
Block	R	Absorb (shield risk)

Resolution Summary

- Roll skill dice + Leverage
- Take **highest die**
- Check for **Partial Critical** (max die)

Outcomes

- **Legendary (24+)** – Major effect
- **Partial Critical** – Extra effect
- **Success** – Goal achieved
- **Success + Complication** – Progress at a cost
- **Failure** – Situation changes

Leverage & Pressure

Leverage (Good Circumstances)

Leverage	Bonus Die
1	d4
2	d6
3	d8
4	d10
5	d12

Pressure (Danger)

- Raises DC
- Does not remove dice

Damage, Armor, and Injury

- **Wounds** are lasting injuries
- **Stamina** is short-term shock
- Armor may convert wounds to stamina
- Negative stamina degrades actions

Injuries affect:

- movement (legs),
- attacks (arms),
- awareness (head).

Fear Effects (Quick)

Fear	Effect
1–2	Alert, cautious
3	Hesitation advancing
4	First hostile action loses 1 anchor
5	Limited to 3 anchors
6	Breakdown / withdrawal

Fear penalizes entering danger, not survival.

Weapon Notes

- **One-Handed:** 1 wound
- **Two-Handed:** 2 wounds
- **Precision:** stamina bleed
- **Chopping:** armor damage
- **Crushing:** ignores mitigation
- **Reach:** wards advances
- **Firearms:** escalation, loud, decisive on crits

Covering Fire (Refined)

- Requires: **L + H**
- No damage
- Target must choose:
  - lose warding, or
  - take the attack
- Partial Critical: both occur

Table Rules

- Declare intent first.
- Fiction > geometry.
- Resolve fast and move on.
- Retreat is success.